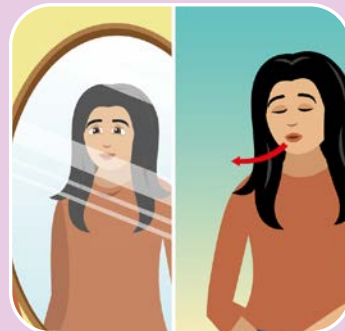
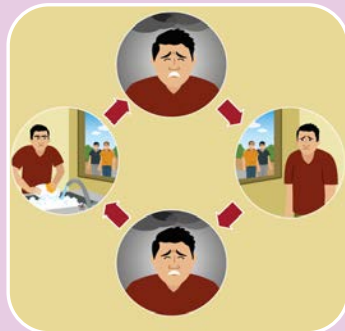


Psychological self-help interventions

Delivering self-help for individuals, featuring Step-by-Step and Doing What Matters in Times of Stress



Web annex Step-by-Step

A self-help intervention
for depression

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Introduction

This document contains information about the Step-by-Step (SbS) intervention and some suggestions for adaptation. It covers:

- a) an introduction to the SbS intervention content (**example version based on content adapted for Lebanon**) (section 1)
- b) an overview of the SbS exercises content (section 2)
- c) adaptation and implementation information (section 3).

To support implementation of SbS, the World Health Organization can provide information and resources to support adaptation and implementation. These include all content needed to implement SbS, including spreadsheets of all storylines, images and example audio exercise files.

Please email psych_interventions@who.int for further information or any questions about implementation.

If you would like to translate SbS, as a first step, please complete the form at <https://www.who.int/about/policies/publishing/permissions>.

Section 1:

Step-by-Step story

This section is the female storyline of Step-by-Step, it is an **example version based on content adapted for Lebanon**. The content is ordered as it was in the original intervention, with an introduction and five modules, each split into parts and then sections of the story. It outlines the SbS intervention in full and can be read end to end. It is not designed to be given to a user in this format, but can be adapted for a book, an animation product or an online platform.

A translation pack is available on request (please email psych_interventions@who.int for further information). It includes this content and the male storyline along with other key information, such as images and text codes to make it easier to use in an online system (see section 3).

Step-by-Step female storyline

Introduction module: Take the first steps

Part 1

Welcome



Welcome to the Step-by-Step programme!

We're so glad to see you here at the start of this journey.

Our programme shares a set of techniques that are known to help people who are feeling sad or stressed.

Let us explain how Step-by-Step works before meeting Dr Luna and some of the persons she helped with this programme.

How does it work?



You are going to complete five modules in our programme.

Each module contains two or three small parts.

Take your time and start at your own pace.

You can try to do the whole module in one day or do the parts over a few days each week.



Completing one module a week will help you stay on track and get the best results.

As soon as you have completed one module, the next one will be unlocked. You can access this new module directly or come back to it later when you're ready.

This break between modules will give you time to practise what you have learnt so far.

What can you learn?



This programme is going to teach you a set of techniques.

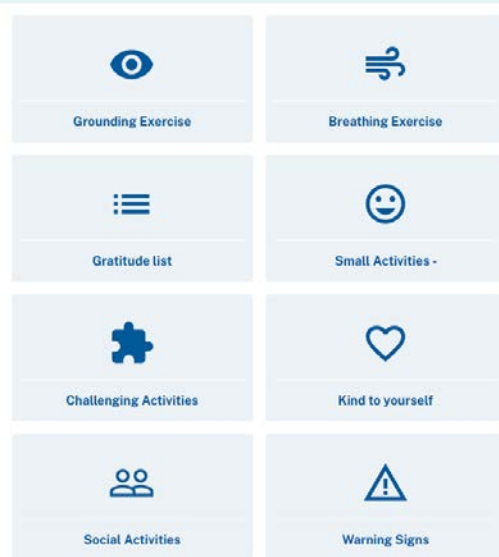
You can use them any time you want to help yourself feel less stressed or sad.

You will learn how to:

1. Reduce stress in the moment
2. Increase activity and do more of what matters to you
3. Be kind to yourself
4. Connect with others
5. Prevent yourself from feeling worse again.

Toolbox

Here you can practice the activities you have unlocked on your Step-by-Step journey



Each technique can help you feel less stressed and sad. They can even give you more energy.

Practising what you learn with us is important.

To make it easier for you to practise these techniques, we have placed them in a toolbox for you.

You can access your toolbox from the menu.

Every time you are introduced to a new technique, you can access it in your toolbox.

This way you can easily find it to practise between modules.

If you have not learnt the technique yet, it will appear as locked.

Tips to make Step-by-Step work best for you



We know this is a lot to take in, so here are some tips to help make Step-by-Step work best for you:

1. Complete modules in a quiet place, if possible. This should be somewhere you feel comfortable and calm.
2. Try to finish one module a week. Remember, a module is made up of two or three parts so that you can do them over a few days.
3. Practise what you have learnt as often as possible. This is one of the most important things you can do.

Now we're ready to introduce you to Dr Luna.

She is going to guide you through our programme.

Part 2***Meet Dr Luna***

Hi there, I'm looking forward to working with you.

My name is Dr Luna.

I will be teaching you what you need to know to start feeling better.

I don't know you yet, but here's what I do know:

You took the decision to join Step-by-Step.

This shows me that you have enough strength to take the first steps in this programme.



Celine and Maya, two persons who came to me for help, have agreed to share how they used the skills I taught them to feel better.

Let me introduce them to you!

Celine is married and has two children. Her mother died, and her father moved in with her family. When she first came to see me, she had to deal with difficult emotions and struggled with her daily activities.

Maya is a student and lives with her mother. After her father left the family, she was under a lot of pressure to study and look after her sick mother. That's when she signed up for Step-by- Step.

Your situation might be different to theirs, but we hope you still find it helpful to hear from them.

You will meet them soon, but first, I would like to introduce you to a technique you can use when you feel stressed.

How to manage stress



Let me introduce you to a new technique that might make you feel calmer.

We call this technique “grounding”.

Grounding can help you be less caught up in your thoughts by focusing more on the here and now.

It can help you take a break from worrying about the past or future.

This can help people feel less stressed.

It may not be easy at first, and it helps to practise it every day if you can.

I’d like you to try it now.



Grounding Exercise

Grounding exercise

This is a recording of the Grounding exercise (approx. 4 minutes) which the user can follow. Grounding brings us back to the present moment and unhooks us when we’re caught up in emotional storms. For script see section [2.1 Grounding exercise](#).

Part 3***How did it go?***

Well done for trying out the grounding exercise.

I hope it made you feel a little less stressed.

If not, that's okay.

It will probably take more than one try to feel the effect of the exercise.

All of the techniques we teach in this programme work best with practice.

It is like doing physical exercise: the more you do, the easier it becomes as your muscles become stronger.

You can even practise the technique when you do not feel very stressed so that you know it better.

You will learn other techniques as you go through this course.

For now, I hope you can practise this one.

One last thing



One last thing...

It is likely that there may be some days when you don't feel like continuing with Step-by-Step.

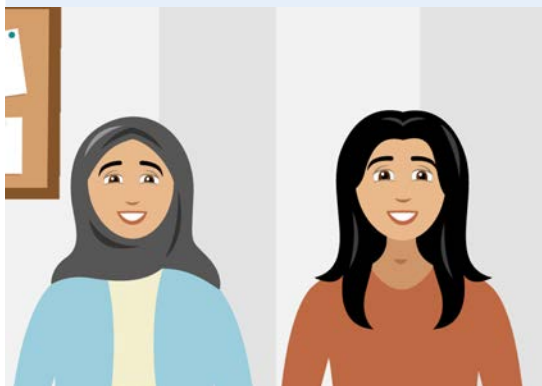
But please, don't give up! It can take a few weeks to feel a difference.

Try to stick with us and see if things change.

Module 1: Start small and reduce stress

Part 1

Introduction to module 1



Celine and Maya tell you their story.

Dr Luna teaches you a new technique to help you feel calmer and less stressed.



It's great to see you back here, ready for this next step.

We hope you had a chance to try the grounding exercise.

If not, you can always find this technique in the toolbox via the menu.

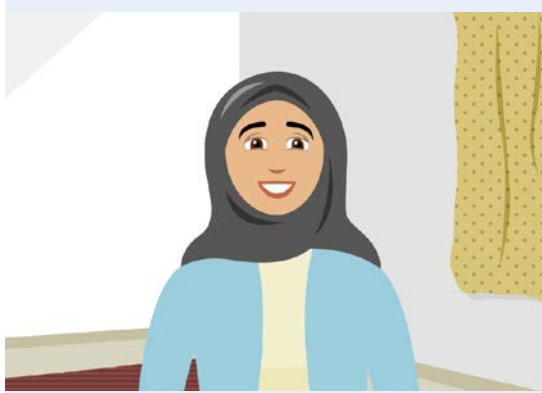
It's time for you to get to know Celine and Maya.

They have also been through difficult times and will share their story with you in this first part of module 1.

You will also have the chance to try a new technique Dr Luna teaches you, called the breathing exercise.

First, let's say hello to Celine and hear her story.

Celine shares her story

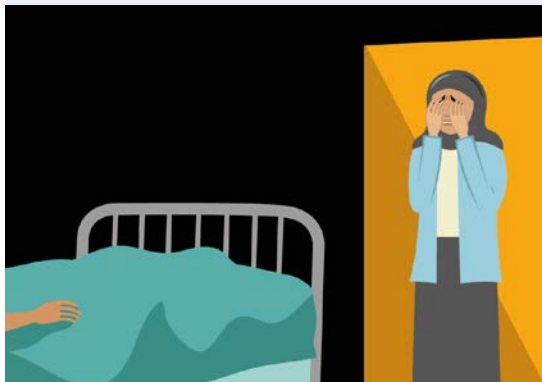


Hi, I'm Celine. I did Step-by-Step some time ago with Dr Luna, in her clinic.

The techniques she taught me helped me through some really difficult times.

And now they've made the programme I did into this app.

When I first started this programme, I had lost things that were important to me.



My mum passed away over a year ago, she was so young.

I should have been there to protect her.

I felt so guilty.

I promised to take care of my dad.

"He has to come and live with us," I told my husband Michel.

He agreed, but we were both anxious.

Our house was very small.

I felt so heavy.



This heaviness stayed for months.

It was as if I was carrying an extra weight.

My shoulders and neck felt so tense, and I didn't want to eat.

I couldn't sleep, even though I felt tired all the time. I lost my appetite, but whenever I felt stressed, I ate unhealthy snacks between meals.

I gained weight and started to dislike the way I looked.



Sometimes I felt so low I couldn't get out of bed in the morning.

This frustrated my husband.

"Please, Celine, I can't prepare for work and take care of the children at the same time."

I knew he was right.

I hated myself for not being the woman he had married.

But I felt so tired and sad.

Now let's hear from Maya, the young student, who also completed Step-by-Step.

Maya shares her story



Hi, I'm Maya.

I know the feeling of sadness that Celine is talking about so well ...

When I signed up for Step-by-Step I was under a lot of pressure.

My dad left us about nine months ago ... my mum fell apart.

I promised to take care of her, and the house. But I had to finish my studies, too.

Most days all I could feel was the weight of his absence.

So heavy ... I could see no way out.



I felt lonely too.

On my course, everyone seemed so carefree and at ease.

They were just students, studied, got together at weekends.

I envied them.

It was hard to connect with anyone ... so I stopped trying.

Besides, I was no fun to hang out with anymore ...

I didn't want to talk to anyone.



Then one day Julia, a friend from class, was waiting for me.

I felt nervous. What does she want with me? We were not that close.

“Hi Maya,” she said, smiling at me. “I wanted to ask if you’re okay?”

I was so shocked that someone had noticed me.

I couldn’t speak. My eyes teared up.

I felt so embarrassed ...

I was sure she would leave me alone like everyone else.

“Let’s sit down,” she said.



We sat together for a long while. It could have been hours before I told her what was happening.

“I feel so tired all the time,” I told Julia. “I’m a mess ... but I have to take care of my mother. There’s so much to do.”

Julia put her hand on my shoulder.

“Maya, I’m so sorry you are going through this,” she said. “It sounds so hard - like you’re carrying the weight of the world on your shoulders.

It’s not the same, but I’ve also been in a bad place. And I know how dark it is there ...”

I couldn’t imagine how someone like Julia could ever feel this way.

But she had.



“When we had to leave our home, we left everything behind,” she explained.

“It broke something deep inside me. I stopped eating and just couldn’t feel happy. Everything was numb for a very long time.”

“But you’re top of the class,” I said. “You seem so ... happy.”

“Really?” smiled Julia. “Things are better now. But it’s been a long journey. When I saw you today, looking so fragile, I saw myself one year ago. I remember feeling so lonely.”



“I feel so alone,” I said. “So tired, so numb, all the time ... I don’t want to do anything any more.”

“Have you thought about seeing a doctor?” asked Julia.

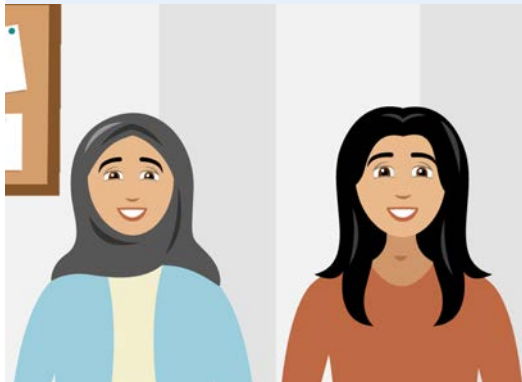
“How can a doctor help me?” I asked, shaking my head.

“It’s a process,” said Julia. “It seemed strange at first, but with the doctor’s guidance, I slowly learnt to do things I enjoyed again.”

But I was feeling so ashamed. I didn’t want anyone to know I was feeling this way.

Now let’s hear from Celine and Maya together, as they have an important message for you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



We both struggled with the idea of talking to someone about what was happening.

We both wondered how a doctor could help someone feel better, and we didn't want to waste their time.

Now we know that there is help out there. You don't have to do everything on your own.

Doctors and health care workers are here to help you, as Dr Luna helped us. It's their profession. They don't judge.

Let's return to Dr Luna. She also has something to tell you.

You are not alone



This is how Celine and Maya were feeling back then.
Perhaps you can relate to their experience in some way?

You might experience it differently, maybe feeling better or worse than they did.

But the techniques you are going to learn in Step-by-Step are helpful for different levels of emotional distress.

When Celine and Maya first came to see me, they had faced some of the hardest moments of their lives.

You might be experiencing difficult moments too.

Please remember, you are not alone.



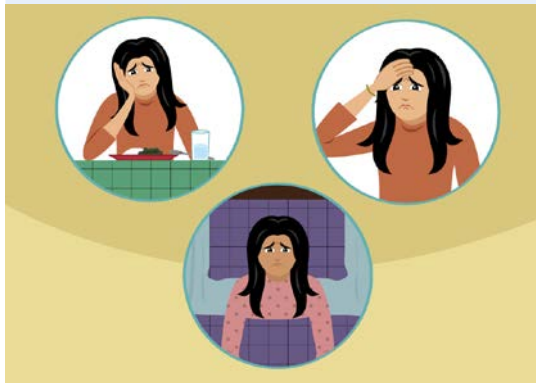
Negative events come in many shapes and sizes.

Some people could be living without enough money, or experiencing unsettling changes in circumstances.

Others might be losing their home or people close to them.

Some people are exposed to violence or affected by a disaster.

Everyone reacts differently to these events.



Like Maya, some people feel extreme sadness: they worry a lot or feel hopeless or nervous.

Sometimes we might feel this way without any obvious reason, and we don't understand why.

Some people have physical complaints after a stressful or negative event.

For example, they may have problems with their appetite or digestion.



Like Celine, there are some people who cannot sleep, or experience other kinds of physical problems such as headaches or back pain.

It is common to feel very tired too.

Sometimes, people can do things like staying away from people, drinking alcohol or using drugs to get away from it all.

But even if these behaviours seem to relieve some pain in the short term, they generally cause more problems and make things worse in the longer term.

When Celine first came to see me, she asked me some very important questions:

“How can I cope with this sadness?”

“When will it end?”

For some people, the feelings of sadness, fear and hopelessness get better over time.

For others, like Celine, these feelings get stuck. It might be the same for you too.



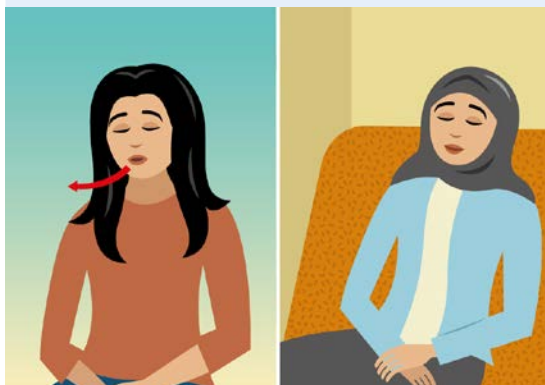
I know it's hard now, but it's important to remember that you are not alone.

It is very common to feel overwhelmed by sadness, worry and stress.

In fact, one in four people all over the world experience emotional distress that really affects them at least once in their lifetime.

Feelings of stress might be normal, but they can have a lot of negative consequences on your life.

How to calm down



It is very useful to know techniques to feel calmer.

You have already been introduced to the grounding exercise to help you feel less stressed.

I would now like to introduce you to a second technique to help you to relax.



This second technique is a breathing exercise.
It may sound strange, but breathing can alter how stressed people feel.

This exercise will show you how to breathe slowly and at a pace that can help reduce stress.

Once you know how to do it, you can use it to help you feel calmer whenever you feel stressed or overwhelmed.

You just need to sit back and try to pay attention to your breathing.

In the next step, just touch the play icon to play the audio file.

You can use this technique whenever you feel you need to reduce your stress.

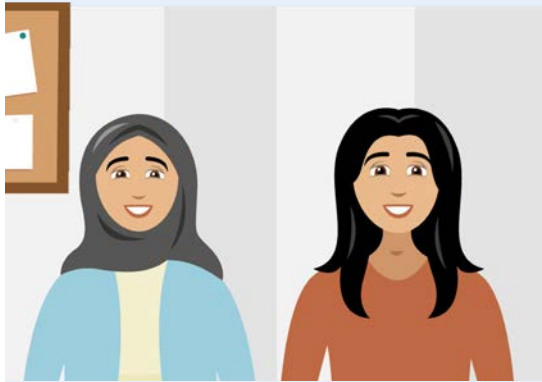
We have now reached the end of part 1 of module 1. You can now either go directly to part 2 of module 1, or do that another time, as you like.



Breathing Exercise

Breathing exercise

This is a recording of the Breathing exercise (approx. 6 minutes) which the user can follow. Slow breathing helps us to reduce stress. For script see section [2.2 Breathing exercise](#).

Part 2***Gratitude list***

Celine and Maya tell you more about the difficulties they faced in their daily life and Dr Luna teaches you a new technique to reduce stress called the ‘gratitude list’.

Celine's daily life



Let's go back to Celine to find out more about the difficulties she faced in her daily life.

Nothing seemed to be working like it used to.

I couldn't find pleasure in my life anymore. Everything felt dull or tiring.

Even food lost its taste.

I used to smile just thinking about cooking, going for a walk, my daughter's laugh ... now it all felt difficult.

I used to help my son with his school work. I loved this as it made me feel good to support him.

Now he avoided me.

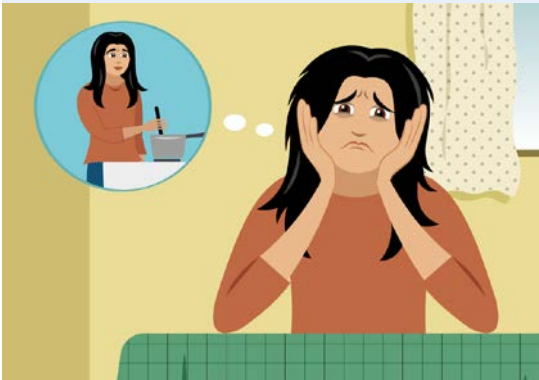
Or perhaps I avoided him ...

It made me feel terrible, but how could he be around a mother who cried all the time?

Everything felt harder... there was always something to resolve.

I dreamed of easier days.

Maya's daily life



There were difficult times for Maya as well. Let's hear about her experiences.

I couldn't see anything good in my daily life any more.

I used to smile just thinking about cooking with my mum, seeing my friends in the class ...

Now I didn't smile at all, and cooking just felt like another chore.

I couldn't enjoy things anymore, not like I used to.

Studying became such an effort. I was so anxious about falling behind.

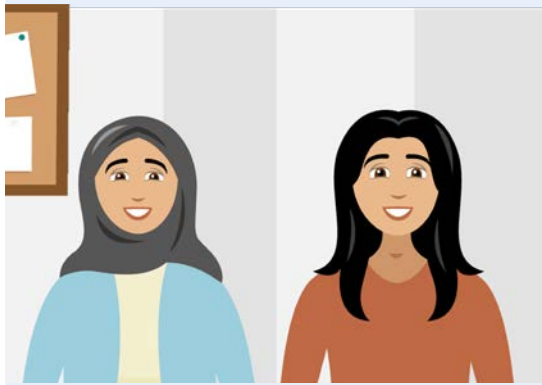
At home, my mum's arthritis made it hard for her to help me around the house.

There was always something to clean or to organize.

Life had been easier with dad around. I just felt numb.

Celine and Maya have been there, like you, and have something to share with you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



When we encounter difficulties in our lives, we can start feeling weak and may lose hope.

When we are feeling down and overwhelmed, we tend to forget the small things that can make a difference in the way we feel.

We'd like to remind you of those small things that you're grateful to have in your life!

Let's go back with Dr Luna, and learn a new technique to help you feel less stressed.

How to reduce stress



It may seem hard to believe, but remembering things we are grateful for, no matter how small, can help reduce stress, especially when practised over time.

In the Toolbox you will find the gratitude list.

To use this technique, take a few minutes to think of three things you are grateful for.

These can be anything, big or small.



For example, think of a person who was kind to you, something you did for yourself, something you did for others, something you learnt, or someone you are grateful to have in your life.

For Maya, it was Julia who helped her reach out for support; for Celine, it was her kids who gave meaning to her life.

It can be any small everyday thing or anything you particularly appreciate in your current life.

On the gratitude list, you can write things you feel grateful for.
You can then return to this list whenever you need it in your Toolbox.

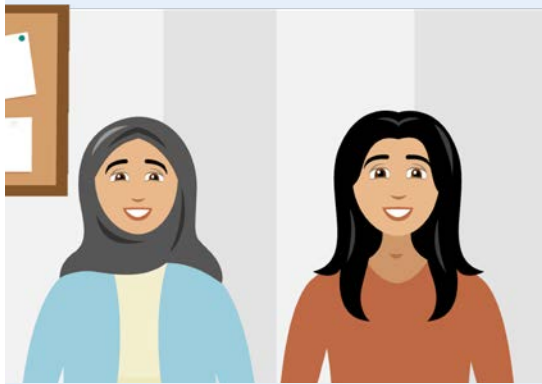
Let's try!

We have now reached the end of part 2 of module 1. You can now start the last part of module 1, or come back another time.

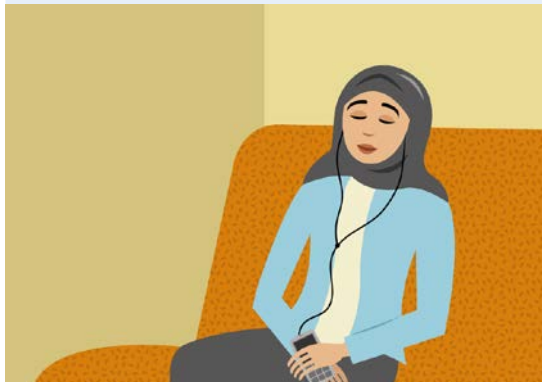


Gratitude list

People are asked to list things they are grateful for.
Making a gratitude list can help to improve mood. For an example see section [2.3 Gratitude list](#).

Part 3***Improving your mood***

Celine and Maya talk about their experiences with Step-by-Step and Dr Luna teaches you a new technique that will help you improve your mood, called the “small activities” exercise.

Celine’s experience with Step-by-Step

Let’s meet Celine again and hear how she practised the activities.

In the beginning, I felt it was hard to try the techniques Dr Luna taught me.

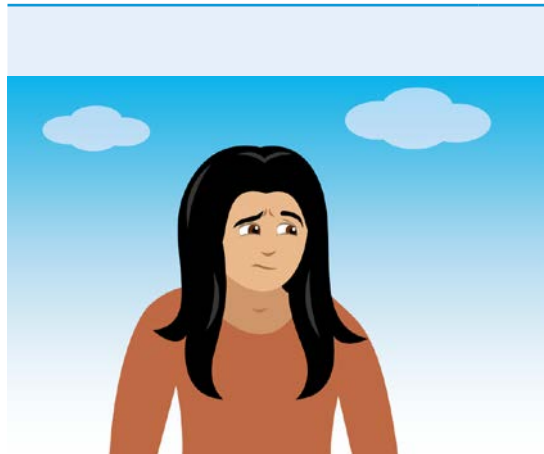
I felt like I was bad at them. It required so much effort and energy.

It made me feel less abnormal to know that other people were struggling with this as well.

So I kept trying. With practice, I noticed that it became easier and I started to feel the activities were helpful.

I started practising the breathing or grounding Exercise each morning before waking up my children, and tried remembering to use them during the day when I felt stressed or overwhelmed.

Maya's experience with Step-by-Step



How was Maya's experience with Step-by-Step ? Let's hear it.

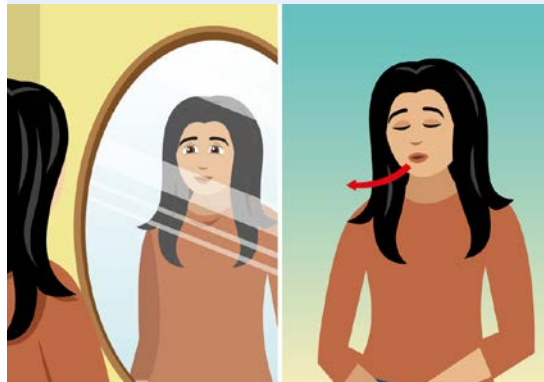
In the beginning, it was hard for me to keep the motivation up and try the activities Dr Luna recommended to me. I couldn't really see how breathing exercises were going to solve my problems but I kept doing them.

Then one day I met my friend Julia in class.

"Are you feeling any better?" Julia asked me.

She knew I had been to see Dr Luna.

I was quite negative.



"I can't really see how breathing exercises are going to solve my problems," I said.

"They won't," said Julia. "But I remember when I began slow breathing, relieving my stress for a moment helped me to start doing small things again. Going outside, seeing people...preparing for the professor's comments on my essays!"

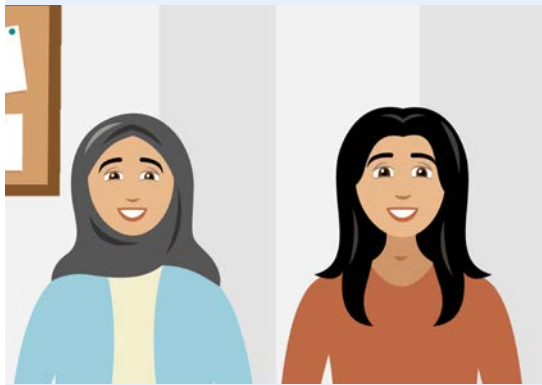
I tried to smile.

"You see?" said Julia. "The small things ... like feeling you can smile again."

I nodded, but inside my stomach twisted with doubt.

From their own experience with Step-by-Step, Celine and Maya want to share a message with you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



Like us, it can take time for activities to feel easier. Even small things can seem huge.

Caring for ourselves helps. You need to take care of yourself too. Self-care includes regular sleeping and eating, even if you don't feel like it.

Let's meet again with Dr Luna and hear how pleasant activities can help improve your mood.

How to boost your mood



Indeed, the better you care for yourself, the better you will start feeling again.

Now I am going to show you how small pleasant activities can actually help improve your mood.

As Maya experienced, the thought of doing even the smallest activity might seem daunting.

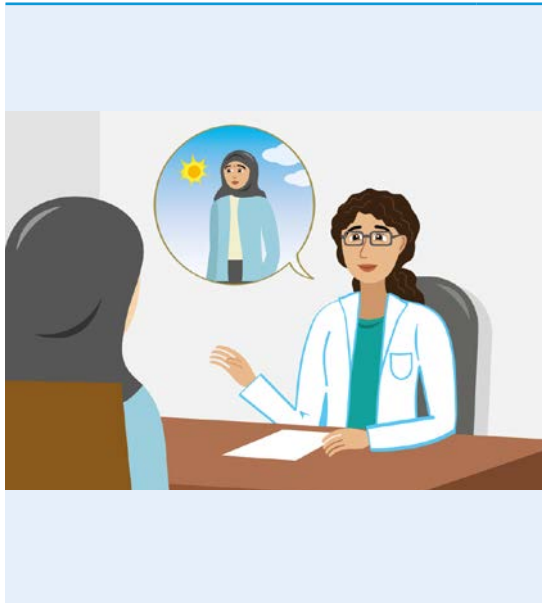
This is normal when we are very sad or feeling very stressed.

Doing something that makes us feel good when we feel this way can help reduce stress and improve mood, if done regularly.

Just taking a few minutes each day to do something pleasant can help.

As you do this, take a moment to notice your mood. After doing the activity, do you feel even the smallest bit better?

With practice, it can lead to bigger improvements in mood.



Please think about one small thing that makes you feel a bit better.

This could be something that you enjoyed in the past and might make you feel a little better now.

Celine had always loved walking but had stopped because she was sad and tired.

She found that taking a small walk again eased the tension in her shoulders.

Gentle exercise actually encourages a naturally occurring reaction in our brains that can improve our mood.

While it doesn't solve our life problems, gentle physical activity is particularly helpful in making us feel better.

And if we feel better it can make dealing with stress in life more manageable.



If we stop doing the things we like, we will start to feel worse.

So, the first step is to start doing small things we used to enjoy doing.

Because what we do can have an impact on how we feel.

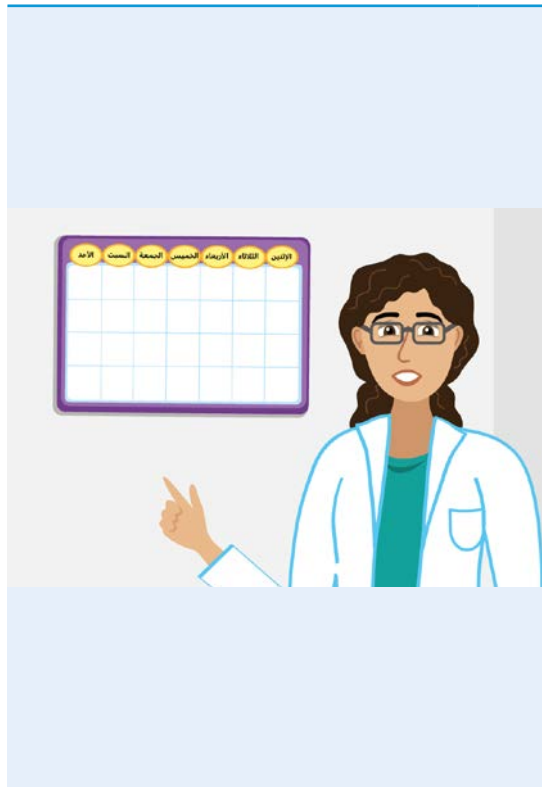
This means you actually have more influence over how you feel than you might think.



After today's module, I'd like you to try to do one thing every day that you enjoy or used to enjoy.

See if it helps you, even if the impact is very small at first.

In this next technique called "small activities", I will ask you to write down three small things you would normally enjoy doing.



You might feel like including the stress reduction exercises we've tried together so far, or Celine's idea of a walk outside.

Try to think of something that made you feel good in the past.

If you're having trouble thinking of small activities, here are some examples:

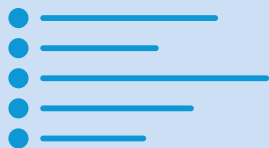
Taking time to enjoy moments with family or friends

- Going for a walk
- Listening to your favourite singer
- Watching a funny film
- Trying the breathing or grounding technique
- Doing something nice for someone else

You can add to your list of small activities at any time.

Just go to your toolbox, where you'll find all your techniques, ready to practise.

Let's give it a try now.



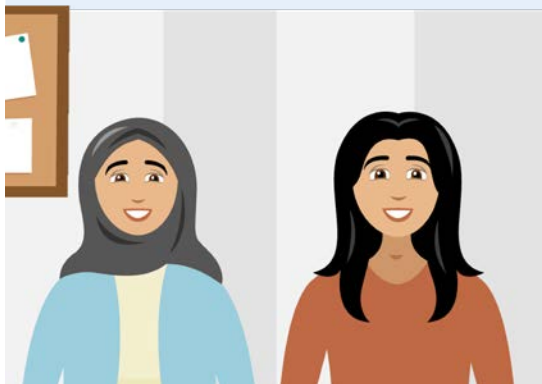
Small activities exercise

People are asked to list small activities they always enjoyed but stopped doing. The small activities exercise shows us that what we do can have an impact on how we feel. For an example see section [2.4 Small activities exercise](#).

Module 2: Break the cycle

Part 1

Introduction to module 2



Celine and Maya tell you about their experiences planning small activities in their daily life.

Dr Luna provides you with further assistance with planning your own activities.



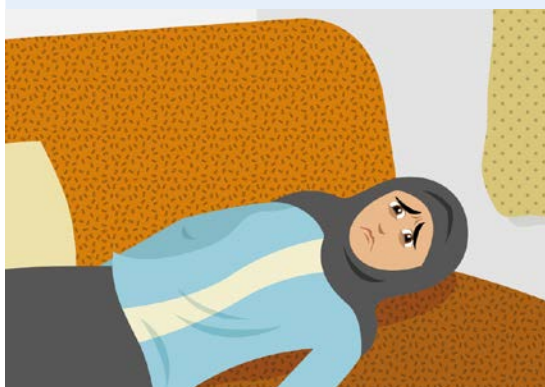
Welcome back to Step-by-Step!

We're happy to see you here in module 2.

We hope you had the chance to practice the stress reduction techniques and small activities exercise since we last saw you.

Let's start the module with Celine.

Celine's experience with small activities



I kept doing what Dr Luna told me.

I made my eating and sleeping habits regular, did the stress management exercises regularly, and planned a small pleasant activity every day.

But it was not easy at all.

I was tired of trying to make myself feel better.



I felt like I was “bad” at the breathing technique. I just couldn’t relax.

I tried the grounding technique too.

Yes, it relieved the pain in my neck for a few minutes ...

But it never lasted very long.

I just couldn’t get into a routine.

When I told Dr Luna this, she said it was normal.

Now let’s hear from Maya and her experience with the small activities exercise.

Maya's experience with small activities

I looked down at my list of things I had once enjoyed.

I had written:

Go for a walk.

What a stupid idea, I said to myself. I have to study and I don't want to see anyone.

But the next day I pushed myself and went because I had learnt it would be better for me.



I felt uncomfortable doing something for myself.

There was laundry to do, I had so much to prepare before class.

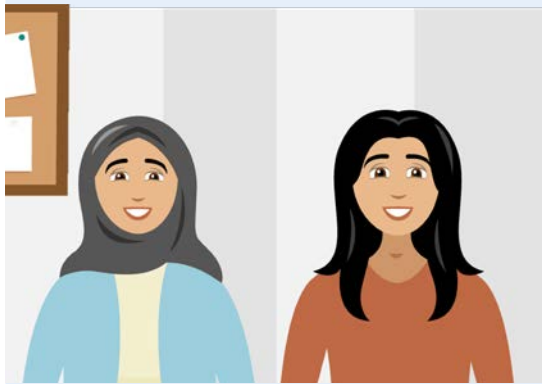
Nevertheless, being outside in the fresh air did me some good.

I found it gave me a bit more energy and I felt a little lighter.

But the next day I woke up feeling sad and overwhelmed again.

Now let's hear from Celine and Maya together, as they have an important message for you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



We both struggled with these exercises at first.

But it's important to keep trying, and it will become easier with practice. Remember that you are doing this because our activities affect how we feel.

Doing small pleasant things for yourself can help you feel better.

Let's return to Dr Luna, she also has something to tell you.

Try something pleasant



Maybe you were not able to try something enjoyable last week.

Or you did, like Maya, and it did not have the effect you thought it would.

Please don't be hard on yourself if that's the case.

It's normal to find some parts of this programme hard.



If you didn't manage last week's activities, you can try them again this week.

It can help to set a reminder.

Some people put a note somewhere, on a door perhaps, or in their wallet or bag.



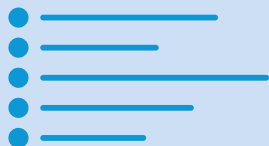
Let's take a look at your list of small activities again.
You can create new entries or edit existing ones if you like.

Try to pick something you enjoy doing and schedule it into your day or week.

I hope you can plan a small activity regularly, so you can start seeing the link between what you do and how you feel.

Let's give it a try.

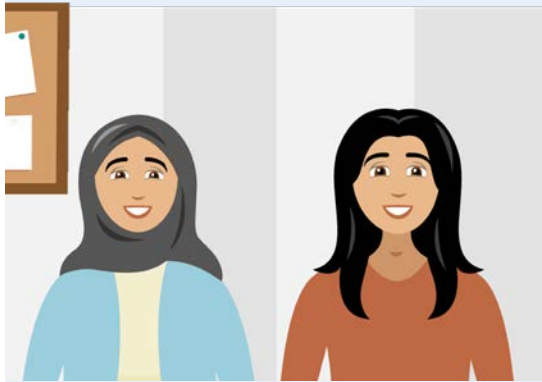
After the activity, you can either continue directly to part 2 of module 2 or start that part of the module another time.



Small activities exercise

People are asked to continue the small activities list.

The small activities exercise shows us that what we do can have an impact on how we feel. For an example see section [2.4 Small activities exercise](#).

Part 2***Learn about the sadness and withdrawal cycle***

In this second part of module 2, Celine and Maya tell you more about their negative feelings.

Dr Luna introduces you to the “sadness and withdrawal cycle” that helped Celine and Maya understand why they felt that way.



Let’s meet Dr Luna again.

I hope you managed to schedule a pleasant activity this week.

Today you will learn a bit more about why doing pleasant activities is important.

Perhaps it has been a long time since you did something you enjoy.

That was how Celine felt. Let’s hear from her.

Celine's struggle with negative feelings

It had been so long since I did things I enjoyed.

I couldn't even remember what they were.

My time was taken up taking care of my children and looking after my dad. I had no energy left.

Everything was such an effort ... people tired me out. I didn't want to be around their happiness.

I hated myself for feeling this way.

I felt that people were thinking: She's a loser.

They were right. I didn't have the energy to be anything else.



"What is wrong with you, Celine?" my husband, Michel, yelled at me one night.

"Don't you think I'm tired of this? Just pull yourself together!"

"Leave me alone!" I would snap back.

"Celine, we cannot go on like this. Something has to change," he said.

Knowing my husband was frustrated made me feel ashamed.

Why can't I be stronger? I asked myself.

This is how Celine felt. Now, let's hear from Maya how this was for her.

Maya's struggle with negative feelings



My life was a strict routine of taking care of the house, my studies and dealing with my mother.

I was always exhausted.

Everything irritated me.

I was feeling like an outsider, not confident in anything I was doing.



“You’ll never find a husband if you act like this!” my mother would yell at me.

“Where is my Maya, who loved to sing and make dinner?”

“Not now!” I would snap back.

“I also miss him,” she said bitterly. “But I don’t hide away from the world.”

Knowing my mother was desperate seeing me like this made me feel even worse.

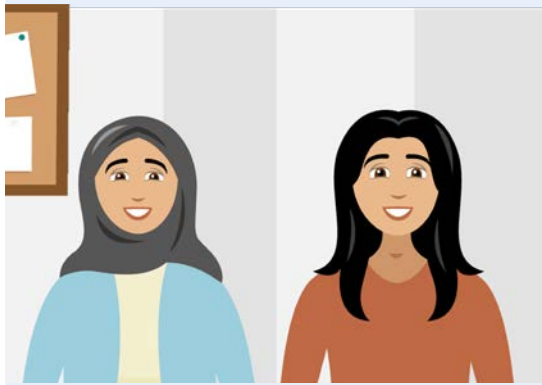


I thought, “I am so tired, and I can’t even sleep. I have no strength. There must be something really wrong with me.”

I was a lost cause.

The less I did, the worse I felt.

Now let’s hear from Celine and Maya together, as they have an important message for you.

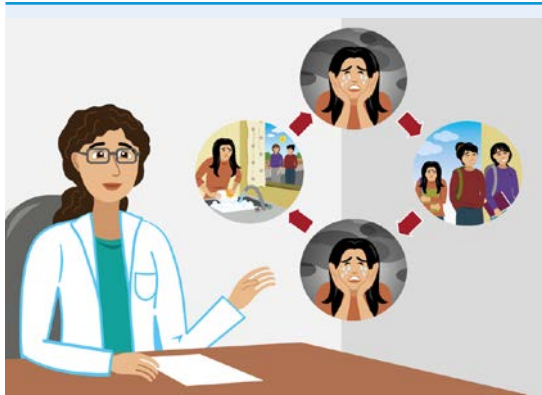
Celine and Maya have a message for you

Like us, you might feel tired, frustrated and unable to do anything to change your situation.

In case you are worrying, this is common and does not mean you are weak.

Keep on trying!

Let's return to Dr Luna, she also has something to tell you.

Enjoyable activities can help you

When people are experiencing low mood, they can feel stuck.

People might carry on doing their daily tasks, but have little energy and feel stressed, so they stop doing activities they normally would enjoy.

This makes them feel worse and they may become more stressed, sad or isolated.

This is called the “sadness and withdrawal cycle”.



Making enjoyable activities a regular part of your life can make you feel better.

Try with something small and build up; just notice if doing things you enjoy or used to enjoy makes your mood change, even if a little.

Remember, you can visit your toolbox whenever you feel low.

If you are struggling to come up with ideas, why not plan some grounding or breathing exercises as small activities?

You can also discuss other helpful activities with your e-helper.

The Mood Tracker



We will introduce you to a new element of Step-by-Step. It is called the “**mood tracker**”.

Keeping track of how you feel can help you see any changes in your mood.

This may help you to realize when it is a good time to do something that makes you feel a bit better.

You can use the mood tracker to help you with this.



Bad



Very Bad



Moderate



Very Good



Good

You can do this in your daily life, whenever and as often as you want.

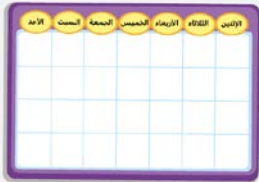
Tracking your mood before and after activities you have scheduled can help you see the difference these activities can make.

To track your mood, go to the ‘mood tracker’ in your toolbox.

Touch the [+] button to pick the face icon that best matches your current mood.

If you do it regularly, you can see a summary of your mood ratings for the day, the week and even the past 14 days by opening the mood tracker in your toolbox.

Your helper will also see your mood ratings, so this is a good way of letting him or her know how you are feeling.



To remind you of the mood tracker, you will sometimes receive a notification when the app is open. You don't have to track your mood if you don't want to.

To see results of your mood tracking open the toolbox. You may have seen this before. Here you can review modules and activities you completed in Step-by-Step. If you choose to track your mood from now on, you will find your mood ratings here.

But there is more! You can also add text, audio or an image to remember what you were doing at that moment when you tracked your mood. This can help you identify what helps you to feel better. This is just for yourself and will never be shared with anyone.

The mood tracker was created to help you understand the link between what you do and how you feel! Why don't you give it a try?

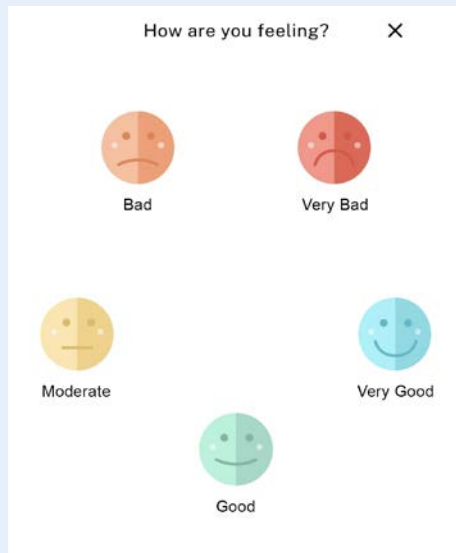


To summarize, today you learnt about the “sadness and withdrawal cycle” and you were introduced to a new tool, the mood tracker, to help you track your mood and progress with Step-by-Step.

I hope this might help you understand how activities can influence your mood.

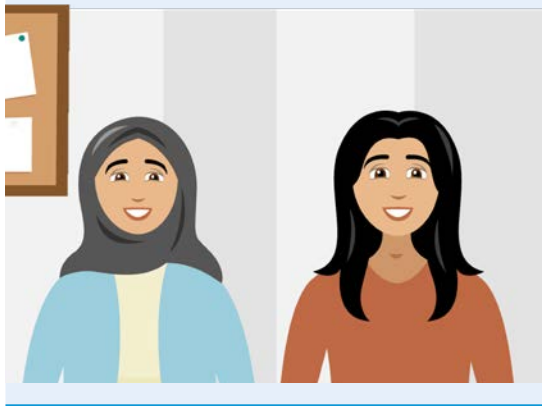
We have now reached the end of part 2 of module 2.

You can now either go directly to part 3 of module 2, or come back later, as you wish.



Mood tracker

The mood tracker asks people to indicate how they feel regularly. Being aware of emotions and tracking them helps us notice patterns in how we feel, making it easier to understand what affects your mood. For an example see section [2.5 Mood Tracker](#).

Part 3***Breaking activities down***

Celine and Maya tell you how they encountered challenges when trying bigger activities in their daily life and Dr Luna introduces you to a new technique, the “breaking activities down” exercise.

Celine tries bigger activities

Let’s first hear from Celine and how she dealt with this challenge.

I had to force myself to keep doing small activities.

It felt tough, but it was helping me feel less sad.

I started seeing that when I did something, I felt a little bit better, less stressed or a bit lighter.

But I knew I had to also take bigger steps.



Walking was okay, but I missed doing things with my family.

Sami was 6 and Nadia was 4 ... they loved walking with me.

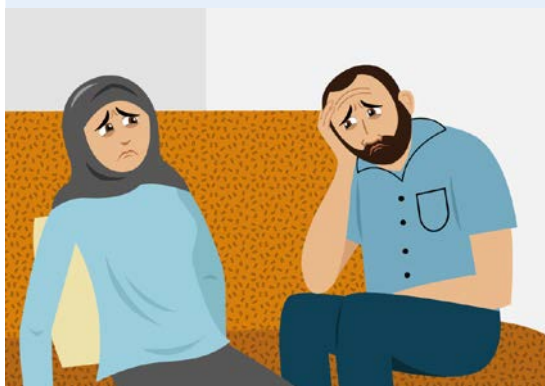
Sunday was my husband's day off, so we would always be together as a family on that day.

I loved the cool breeze by the sea, laughing with my children, going for a picnic.

Those days seemed like a lifetime ago.

When I told Dr Luna this, she said:

Aiming to do bigger activities like spending time with your children will boost your confidence and may help you feel better, Celine.



So, I suggested the idea to my husband.

"If you think it will help" he said. "Just don't let the children down, okay?"

"I won't ..." I promised. I felt ashamed my husband would think this of me.

But when Sunday came, doubts raced around my mind.

I felt so tired.



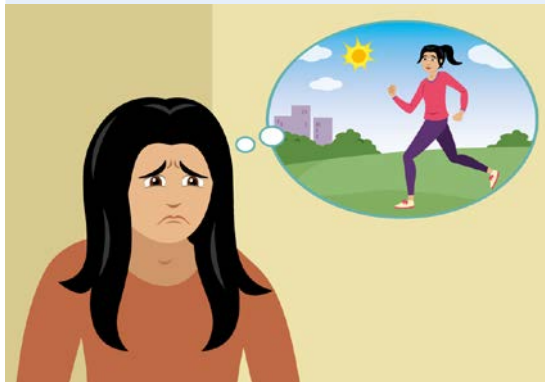
The thought of a trip exhausted me. There was too much to prepare – the food, the children, the journey.

My heart was pounding. How could I go out in the traffic? There would be people, cars, talking ...

“I can’t do it,” I broke down, shaking my head. I knew my husband would hate me.

This was Celine’s first experience with trying bigger activities. Let’s hear now from Maya and see how it went for her.

Maya tries bigger activities



Going outside was okay, but I missed moving my body and doing regular exercise.

When I was younger, I had raced in school competitions.

My dad had called me his little champ ...

I remembered the thrill of watching the sun rise over the sea as my legs raced through our hometown.

Hair flying, heart pumping

I had felt like a champion.

When I told Dr Luna, she advised that trying running again may help me feel better.



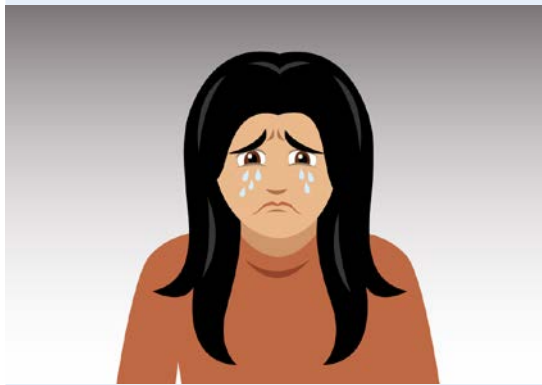
So, I suggested the idea to my mother.

“Studying, running ... when will I see you?” my mother said.

Mama looked sad, even neglected.

But I think deep down she was pleased I wanted to be more active.

“I have to try something, Mama,” I told her. “I want to be stronger, like you.”



However, when the morning came, doubts raced around my mind.

Will I be able to do this without having to stop? Would my clothes fit? Will people look at me and think: she is really unfit?

How could I step out into the world, in my sportswear, when I was so out of shape? And with so much pain in my chest?

And didn't I have so much studying to do?



“I thought you were going for a run?” my mother said when I joined her in the kitchen.

I just couldn’t do it.

I knew she would be disappointed.

“Well, just do something,” she snapped. “I’m tired of this attitude, Maya.”

I felt myself snap.

“Do you not think I’m tired of you?” I screamed at her. “Yes, you! Always criticizing me! Leave me alone!”

“Maya, wait!” she called after me.



But her words had wounded me. I went back to bed and cried myself to sleep.

I woke up feeling so guilty.

My poor mother ...

I didn’t do much else that day.

Let’s hear the advice that Dr Luna gave Maya and Celine at this challenging moment.

Dr Luna's advice



Celine and Maya were trying to do something big that felt too difficult to do because they were worried about many different things.

I told them that they could make their life easier by breaking bigger activities into smaller steps.

I asked Maya: “To go on a small run, what would you have to do to prepare? Why not try to write it down, step by step.”

Let's see how Maya applied this advice.

Maya goes step by step



I felt so ashamed of letting myself down.

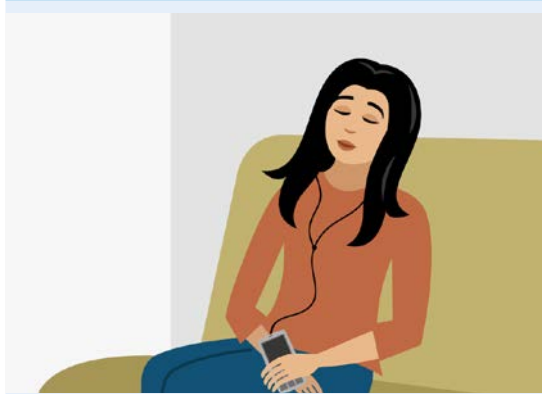
I knew I had to try what Dr Luna suggested if I wanted to run again.

So, I wrote it all down:

1. Check weather forecast
2. Try outfit for running and get a new one if needed
3. Plan a small, achievable route in an area I know
4. Eat something small for energy beforehand

I decided I would run on the weekend when I had no classes.

Otherwise, I knew it would be too much ...



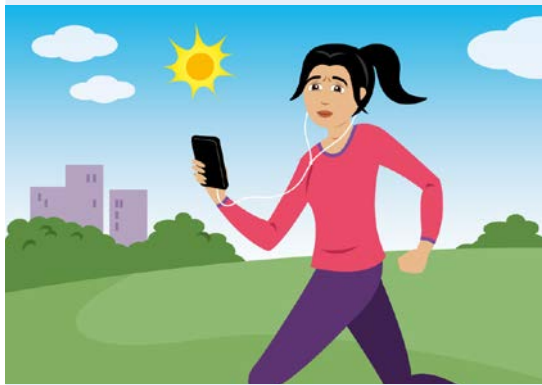
But when Sunday morning came, I felt tired and had a terrible ache across my shoulders and neck.

I told myself:

Maybe it would be better to wait until another time?

But no, I knew I had to try it. So I listened to my breathing exercise to calm my anxieties.

As I relaxed, the pain left my shoulders.



I dressed myself, making sure I felt okay in my sportswear.

I ate a banana to give myself some energy. This already made me feel better ...

I planned out a safe route to reassure myself I would not get lost.

I typed in the route to the map app on my phone ...

When I started to run, my legs resisted the new exercise.



My muscles ached, my heart pounded in my chest and I began to sweat.

At first, I felt self-conscious of my body in public. But soon I could only focus on catching my breath.

And then it came: that familiar, happy sensation of moving myself through space and air ...

It did not last very long, and I soon became exhausted.

But even though I had to stop and walk after one kilometre, I was glad I had tried.

That night, I was so exhausted ... I could have slept for a thousand years, but I also felt proud of myself.

This is how Maya began to run again. Let's hear now how Celine applied Dr Luna's advice.

Celine lists small steps



At the beginning I was confused, how could small steps help me spend a Sunday by the sea with my family?

But, I wrote it all down as Dr Luna suggested to me:

1. Check weather forecast
2. Go to the grocery store to get food and bottles of water
3. Make picnic night before
4. Pack picnic + other things we'd need
5. Take public bus to the beach

Those days, I never went out with both children. They chased cats and the traffic terrified me.

I decided I needed to try this before Sunday, without my husband.

I did it, I went out with my children to the grocery store and it went well.



But when Sunday morning came, I felt like I couldn't get out of bed, so tired. But, I knew I had to try it.

I listened to my grounding exercise to calm my anxieties.

I could tell Michel was on edge. He was expecting me to cancel, to stay in bed.

But I had followed my list to the last point, even though it had taken all my energy.

I packed the picnic and gently got the children ready to leave.



We spent an entire day on the beach.

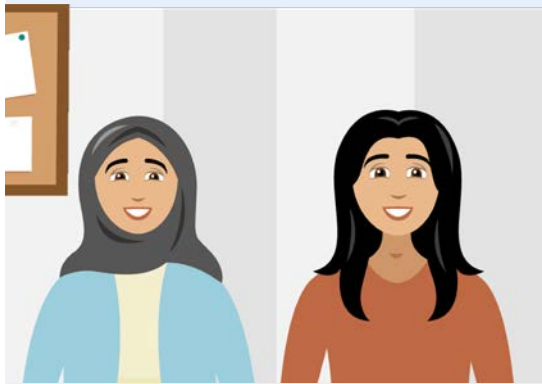
I felt the sea breeze on my skin. I even smiled once, when my son gave me a beautiful shell.

The whole day was exhausting, but I made it.

And that night, when we got home, I could tell Michel and my children were more relaxed. They had enjoyed spending time together.

Now let's hear from Celine and Maya together, as they have an important message for you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



Visiting the sea with family or going for a run again was something we could barely imagine doing. We were so anxious.

But breaking the activities into manageable steps enabled us to do something that made us feel better.

Let's return to Dr Luna, she also has something to tell you.

How to deal with activities that seem overwhelming



If you feel you would like to try something that seems overwhelming, you can break your activity down into smaller and easier steps too!

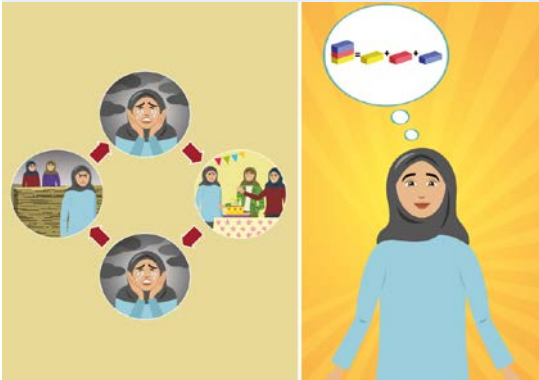
In the next exercise, I am going to ask you to make a list of activities that are too big to try in one go.

Please think about an activity you would really like to do.

This should be something you used to enjoy doing but now seems overwhelming.

It can help to choose something clear and specific, and something you can plan for.

Try something that feels overwhelming, but don't go for the most overwhelming activity too soon.



Just as Celine and Maya did, let's break the activity down into all the essential steps.

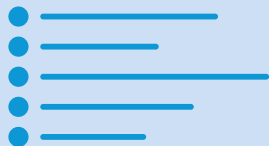
Let me give you an example to help you:

I would like to tidy the house.

If I break this activity down into manageable steps, here are the steps I'd have to think about:

1. Getting out of bed
2. Getting dressed appropriately to tidy
3. Planning which cleaning materials, I might need
4. Clean the bathroom and kitchen
5. Make beds
6. Sweep the floor

Your own chosen activity might be easier if broken down into smaller steps.



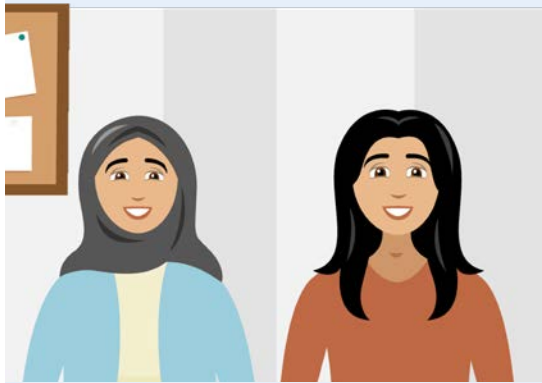
Breaking activities down exercise

This exercise asks people to break down more challenging activities into smaller more manageable steps. For an example see section [2.6 Breaking activities down exercise](#).

Module 3: Be kind to yourself

Part 1

Introduction to module 3



Celine and Maya tell you more about how they were feeling while trying the Step-by-Step exercises, and Dr Luna will remind you of the different techniques you have already learnt.



Welcome back to Step-by-Step!

It's great to see you here at the start of Module 3.

We hope the last few modules have been helpful for you.

If you are feeling unsure if Step-by-Step is working for you, please keep trying – as you'll see now, having doubts about it is common.

Let's first hear about Maya's experience.

Maya feels unsure



I felt unsure if Step-by-Step was working for me.

It made me feel a bit better to know others also felt this way ... at least I wasn't the only one feeling stuck and lost.

But I was still struggling a lot.

I could see that what I did, or didn't do, really had an impact on my mood and on my body.



Taking a small walk or making time for myself did help me feel a bit better.
The breathing and the grounding exercises calmed me down...

But it was so hard to keep my motivation up.

Taking that first run had been a big deal for me.

It had felt good to try something that felt normal ... like the old me.

I now knew that I could do the things I love. I just had to break them up into manageable steps.

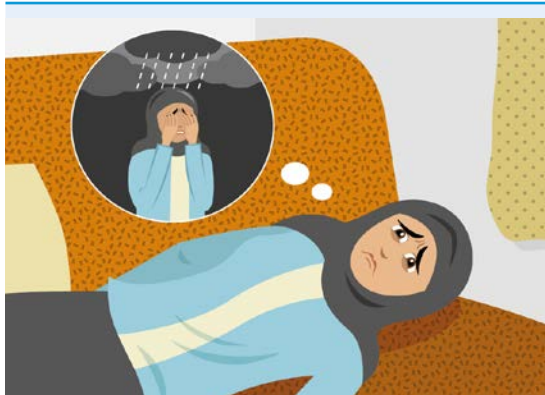


But it still exhausted me ...

And when I was tired, the negative thoughts flooded back.

Now let's hear from Celine and her experience with the programme.

Celine feels overwhelmed



Some days it just felt strange to do more, when I felt like doing nothing at all.

I started to wonder if I was right for this programme.

Maybe I was doing the exercises wrong? Maybe I just wasn't "good" at life ...

Surely, if I felt so tired, I should just stop doing all these things that required so much effort and energy, right?



I have managed to do something I enjoy, by splitting it into smaller tasks.

The trip to the beach with my family had been a big deal for me and I finally did it.

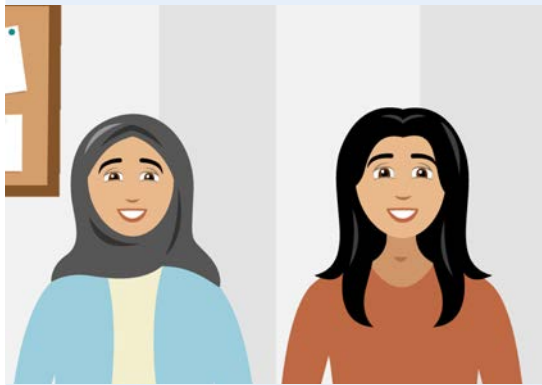
It felt so good to spend time with my family, almost like how it was before I started feeling down ...



However, some days seemingly small tasks were overwhelming, and guilt and shame about the incomplete tasks were coming back ...

Now let's hear from Celine and Maya together, as they have something to say to you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



If, like us, you are having a hard time with Step-by-Step or with the exercises, remember that you were feeling down for a long time until you sought help.

Getting this far shows that you are working hard on improving your life.

You should be really proud of yourself.

Let's return to Dr Luna, she also has something to tell you.

Positive changes take time



Hello, it's good to see you back here for module 3.

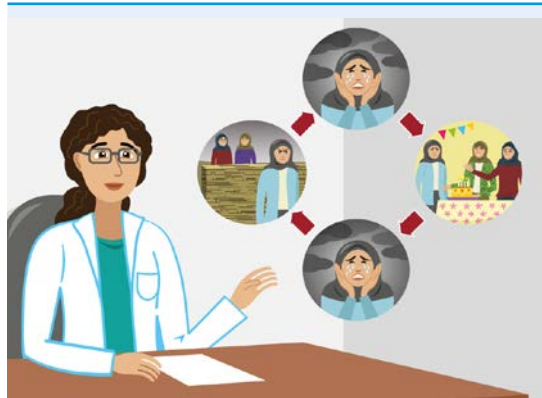
Can you somehow relate to Celine's or Maya's stories?

Maybe you are unsure if this programme is helping you, too?

As you heard from Celine and Maya, it's normal to still feel overwhelmed at this stage.

If you are doing well with the activities, congratulate yourself, because you can see from Celine's and Maya's stories that this is not the case for everyone.

If you are having a hard time with Step-by-Step or with the exercises, remember that you sought help and that is a first step to feeling better.



Positive change does not happen overnight.

It takes time to get out of the “sadness and withdrawal cycle”.

In the time before you sought help, your body and mind got used to feeling the way they did. They got trained into it.

You are now training more pleasant feelings again by doing small, enjoyable activities.

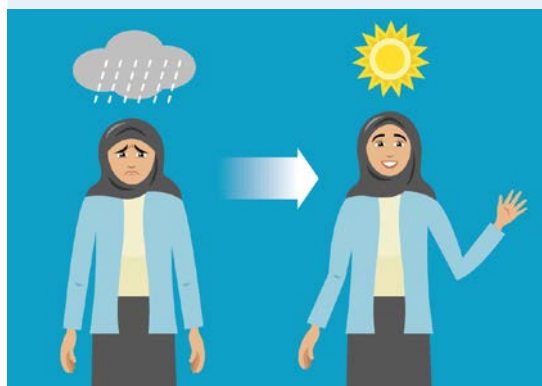


It will take time, and it is normal to doubt or worry while doing this.

That is why practice is so important.

You have learnt several new techniques so far, which you can use whenever you want.

In your toolbox you can find the grounding and breathing exercises, and your gratitude list.

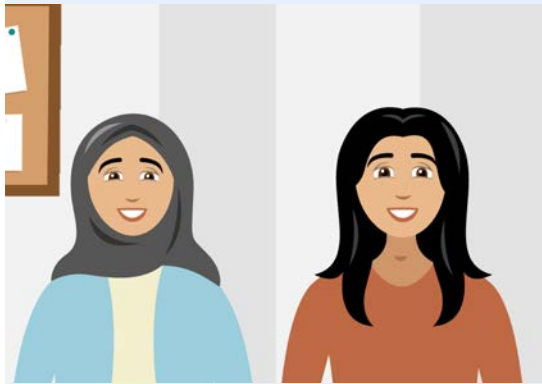


Using these when you are feeling low or stressed can be really helpful, especially if you practise them regularly.

You don't have to use them all, just try the ones that help you the most. Remember you can schedule them in your agenda.

At the end of this part, check your toolbox and take some time to consider what techniques you would like to use more often.

You can now go directly to the second part of module 3, or come back to it later, as you wish.

Part 2***Meeting with friends***

Celine and Maya tell you about their worries and how they felt when meeting friends.

Dr Luna will introduce you to a new technique that can help called the “kind to yourself” exercise.

Celine’s experience meeting friends

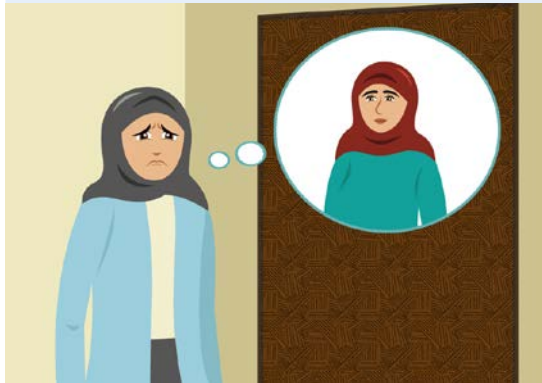
Let’s go back to Celine and hear how she felt about meeting her friends.

I always slipped back into negative thoughts.

And then I would blame myself for being useless.

I could think of every possible excuse to cancel my plans, even though everything was ready and in place.

One morning I had planned to have tea with Mona and another friend, Sara, but I just couldn’t face it.



“Sure, see you there!”

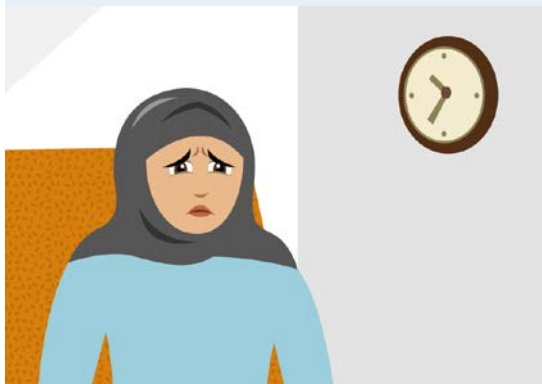
I had messaged Mona on Whatsapp.

But that morning, I woke up feeling so heavy.

It took me longer than usual to gather my strength and get up ...

I worried about what my friends would say about me.

“She nags, she’s selfish, she’s gained weight ... why doesn’t she take better care of herself?”



I spent so long worrying and feeling anxious that it became too late to go.

I hated myself for being so useless.

While imagining what they could say about me, my heart started pounding and I felt sweaty.

I could not stop worrying and thinking badly about myself.

My thoughts went in circles, and I felt worse ...

This is how Celine felt. Now, let’s hear from Maya and see how this was for her.

Maya's experience meeting friends



One afternoon Julia invited me to join some friends from class for coffee.

I felt so anxious. I was feeling ashamed to say no again ... so I agreed to join them.

I worried about what the girls in my class would say about me.

“She’s quiet, she’s unkempt, she always disappears after class ... What’s wrong with her?”



My chest felt so tight!

At some point, I even started worrying whether there was something wrong with my heart.

I was panicking ... in pain ...

I had to call Dr Luna ...

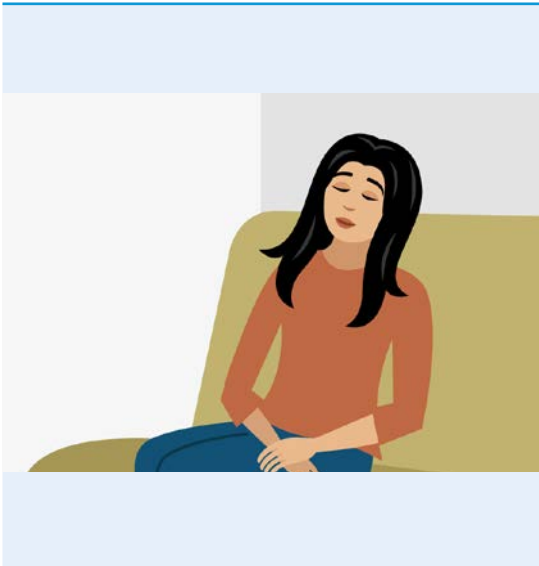
This is what she said:

It seems that the idea of meeting your classmates was very stressful for you, because you were worried that they might judge you for how you feel.

When you are worrying too much, it is normal that your heart rate goes up, you start sweating and your thoughts go really fast.

A grounding exercise may help you feel less stressed.

Would you like me to guide you through it on the phone?



The grounding exercise calmed me down. In our next meeting, when I told Dr Luna what had made me feel so distressed, she said:

You have very negative thoughts about yourself, and you assume that everyone else thinks the same about you.

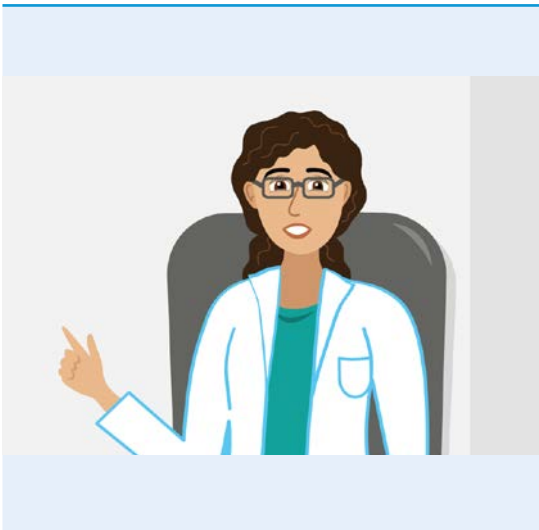
I realized that this was true.

It wasn't that my friends had actually said this about me.

It was me thinking that they would say bad things.

I had assumed that they would have the same negative thoughts about me that I had about myself.

Dr Luna's advice



When someone feels stressed or down like Celine or Maya, it is common that they have very critical thoughts that are not accurate.

It is important to try and be kind to yourself, even if this feels strange.

Imagine a friend telling you that they were planning to do something but couldn't do it because they were having a bad day.

What would you say to them?

What would you do?

Let's see how Maya responded to these questions.



I thought about it for a moment.

I knew I'd say:

"That's okay, please take care of yourself. Just try your best and let me know if there's anything I can do to help."

Maybe I would reach over and offer a supportive hug, or a tissue if they were crying?

I opened my eyes and saw Dr Luna smiling at me.

You are so understanding and caring to others, Maya.

What do you think would happen if you tried to be that for yourself?



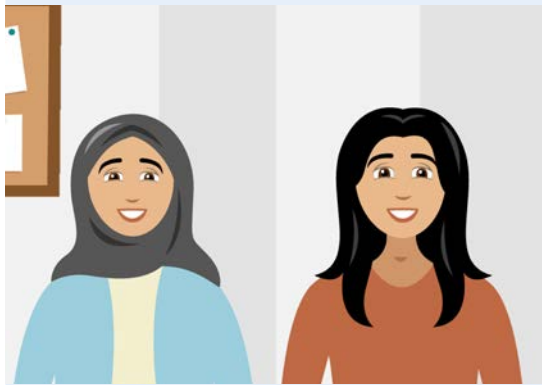
She was right. It was such a simple idea.

I felt a sudden moment of sadness because for a long time I had not been as kind to myself as I could be, or as I would be to a friend.

And I would never speak to a friend the way I spoke to myself.

Now let's hear from Celine and Maya together, as they have something to tell you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



We were very harsh on ourselves when we were finding it hard to do something.

Perhaps you are also harsh on yourself?

Being an encouraging friend to yourself is important in moments of doubt and distress.

It can also help you stay on the right track and keep up your positive activities.

Learn to be kind to yourself



Try to imagine the things you might say to a friend facing a difficult situation so you could say the same to yourself.

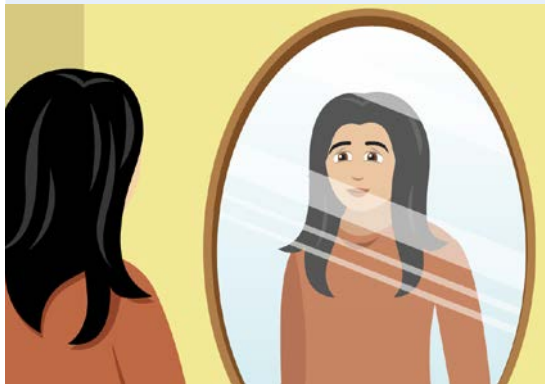
Some examples are:

“It’s okay to feel like this, many people do.”

“These activities are hard, but they will get easier.”

“I am really helping myself by taking these steps.”

“I am trying my best, and that’s okay.”



What would you say to yourself to show kindness and support?

Let's go to a new technique called kind to yourself in your toolbox

I would like you to create at least one entry with kind words to yourself. If you can't think of anything, copy one of the examples above.

This list works exactly like the lists before.



Remember, these words of kindness are available to you whenever you want to read them.

You can always find them in your toolbox.

Stay positive, you are doing well.

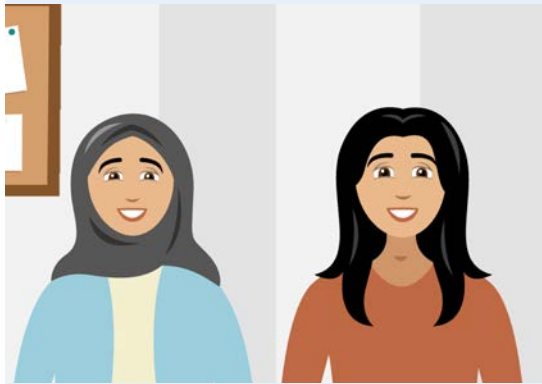
As always, you can now go directly to the third part of module 3, or come back to it later, as you wish.



Kind to yourself

Kind to yourself exercise

The being kind to yourself exercise asks people to list kind words and actions to themselves. For an example see section [2.7 Kind to yourself exercise](#).

Part 3***Kind to yourself***

Celine and Maya give you an example of how they used the Step-by-Step techniques when meeting friends.

Dr Luna reminds you how you can anticipate such challenges and prepare for them.

Celine anticipates the challenge

Let's hear first from Celine.

Mona said we could rearrange having tea for another morning, so we did.

"We meet up often," she said when I apologized to her the next day. "Don't worry about it, Celine. Next time!"

But I had a feeling that next time I would cancel again ... I already felt guilty.

I couldn't rely on myself, and nor could anyone else.



I also knew I had to be kinder to myself

Dr. Luna was right ... I couldn't be so hard on myself any longer.

If I felt stressed about meeting my friends, I would do a grounding exercise before going out and say some kind words to myself.

Now let's hear which technique Maya chose to meet this challenge.

Maya manages her stress

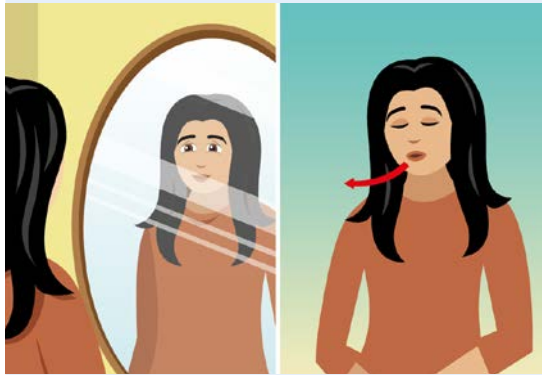


When the next meeting with Julia and my friends came, I started worrying again.
I thought: What would they think of me if I cancelled again?

I felt the same panic in my chest and I criticized myself, saying how unreliable and pathetic I was.

But this time I became aware that I was having negative thoughts about myself again.

That's not nice, I thought, firmly. And I told myself, it's okay to feel this way.



To make myself feel better, I sat down and did a breathing exercise, which calmed me down.

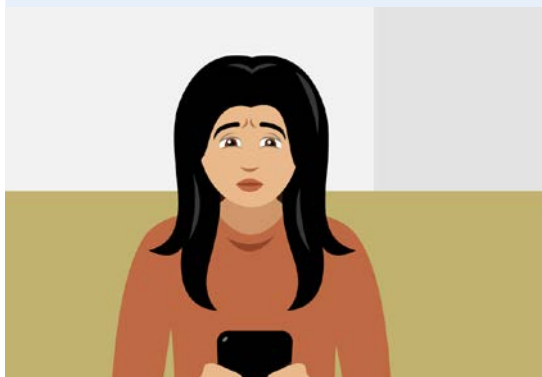
It took a while for my heart to stop racing.

Slowly, the whirling thoughts slowed down ...

I still felt bad.

But I could motivate myself to shower, brush my teeth and get dressed.

I learnt something important about myself that day.



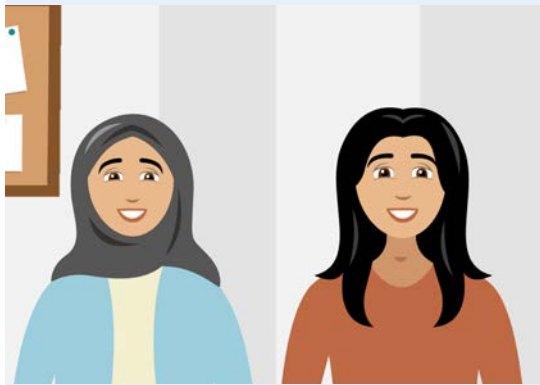
Stress was managing me – when I should be managing my stress.

My phone bleeped. It was Julia:

“Hey Maya! How are you? Everyone’s looking forward to meeting you – see you at 3?”

Let’s hear now from Celine and Maya; they have a message for you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



We were hard on ourselves, and it changed negatively the way we felt.

This is because how we think and how we feel are linked.

If we think badly about ourselves, we will experience negative feelings.

Try to be kind to yourself even when you feel low!

Dr Luna also has something to tell you. Let's return to her.

Get prepared for challenges

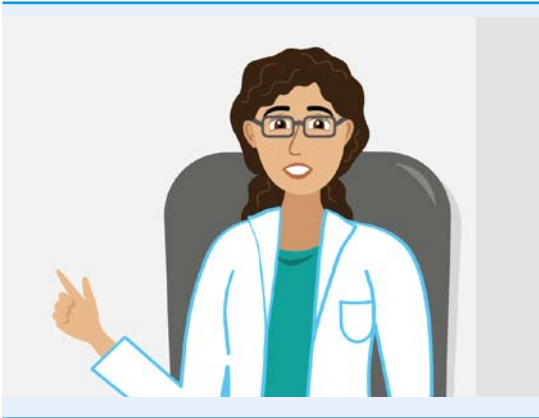


Anticipating when things will be difficult is also an important part of managing your stress.

Maya found that planning to do a Breathing Exercise in advance helped her to complete something she had planned to do.

Celine realized that doing the Grounding Exercise before going out and saying some kind words to myself helped her to manage stress..

Try to think about the things that prevent you from completing your own activities. And then try to figure out how to overcome these difficulties.



We now will go to your toolbox, where you can access your list of overwhelming activities.

This time, think about any problems you foresee coming up with the activity.

You can then write down how you can overcome these challenges using your techniques, or other ideas you might have.

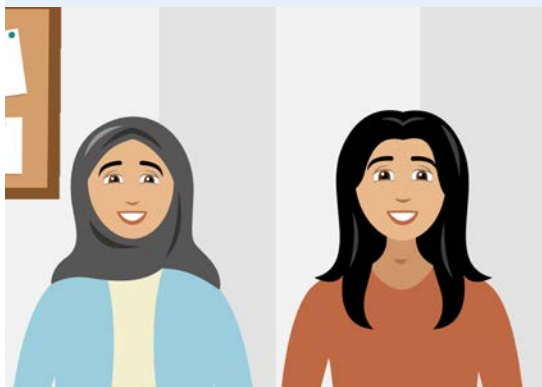
You have now reached the end of this module.

You can now continue to module 4 or review module 3.

Module 4: Connect with others

Part 1

Introduction to module 4



Celine and Maya meet their friends. Dr Luna introduces a new technique, the social activities exercise.



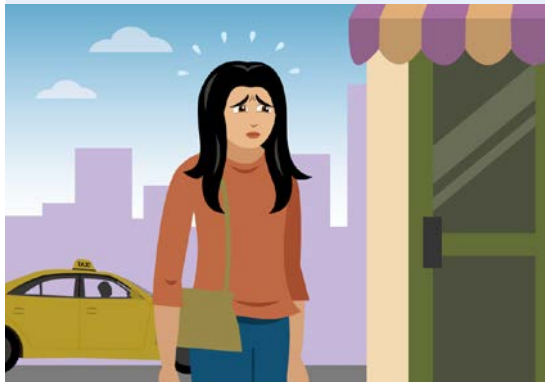
Welcome back to Step-by-Step!

It's great to see you back here in module 4.

You've done so well to get this far.

Let's start part 1 with Maya and hear about her experience of meeting friends.

Maya meets her friends



I stepped out of the cab. I had reached the café where my classmates were meeting.

My palms were sweating.
My legs were shaking.

I felt like everyone was staring at me as I walked through the door.

I thought: Should I just go? Look, the cab is still there ...

I took out my phone to send Julia a Whatsapp message, saying something urgent came up and I couldn't join.



“Maya!”

I turned and saw Julia arriving at the same time. “I am so glad to see you here!” she said, pulling me into a hug.

She led me over to the small group of students that sat nearby.



“Guys, you know Maya from class,” said Julia.

“Hi,” I said shyly.

Julia was so confident. I really wished I was more like her.

“Hey Maya,” a couple of the girls smiled. “Come sit with us.”

Let’s hear now how it went for Celine.

Celine meets her friends



When I arrived at Mona’s place, Sara was already there.

“Hi, Celine! I’m so glad to see you here! Just like old times,” smiled Mona welcoming me.

“Except the husbands aren’t here... or the children!” laughed Sara. “Come sit, Celine.”

I took my seat cautiously, forcing a smile. I felt my stomach tighten, afraid of their questions.

But no questions came.



For a while, I followed their conversation quietly, a bit shy to be in company.

But seeing my two friends laughing and chatting put me at ease.

I felt myself relax.

I even started to enjoy myself.

Mona must have told Sara not to say anything about my problems.

It wasn't until we left Mona's place that she gave me a reassuring hug.



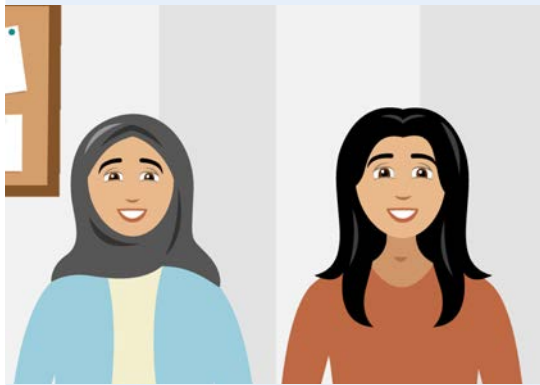
"You know, Celine, if you ever need help, you just have to ask," she said.

I said nothing. I knew that if I opened my mouth I would cry.

But my friend's smile told me she had felt my gratitude.

Let's hear from Celine and Maya together, they have something to tell you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



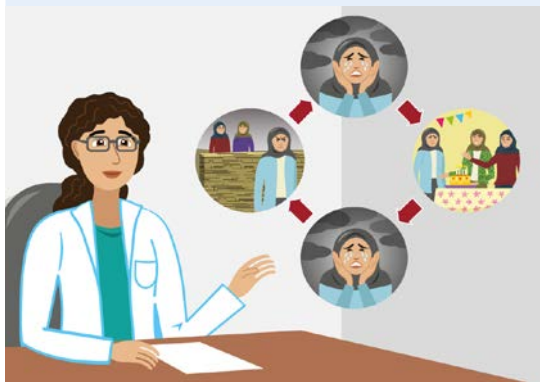
We were feeling so nervous about seeing our friends again.

If you're anxious, even about meeting close friends, then know that there are other people, like us, who struggled with this as well.

Helping others and accepting help from others are important steps in feeling better in your daily life.

Let's return to Dr Luna, who will introduce you to the social activities exercise.

Spend time with others



I hope you are finding ways to be kind to yourself since we last met.

Could you somehow relate to the stories of Celine and Maya?

It is important to remember that the “sadness and withdrawal cycle” can stop you from seeing other people.

You might start feeling worse because of this.

For this reason, it is important to try to spend time with others, even if it feels hard, just like Maya and Celine found it hard.

This could be with a friend, someone in your family, or a neighbour.



This is another way of breaking the sadness and withdrawal cycle.

In general, seeing others helps us feel better.

So now it's time to think about social activities you might like to try, even if they seem difficult right now.

If you have not stopped seeing other people, you can use the next exercise to reflect on which social contacts you would like to strengthen.

Our social network is so important. It's worth the effort.

In the next exercise I would like you to make a list of social activities that you would like to start doing again.



Why not think of something you used to enjoy doing with someone, which now seems quite overwhelming?

Or something you would like to do more of.

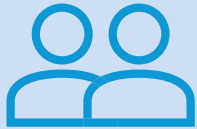
Some people would choose to invite their friends over for dinner ...

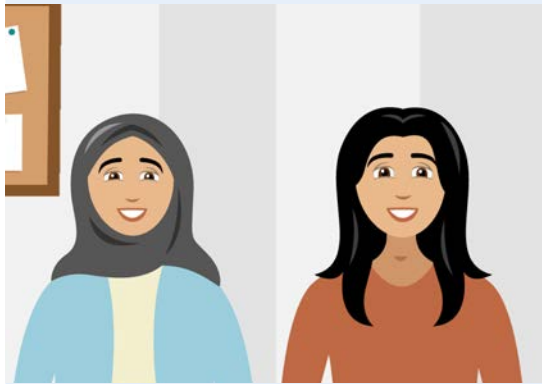
Other people enjoy family gatherings or meeting friends or neighbours for coffee.

This may feel difficult for you.

If you feel this way, don't worry.

Planning and trying them can make socializing a possibility for you again.

	Let's think of one social activity you can try now. This list works exactly the same as the previous lists, like small activities and breaking activities down. You can create entries and break them into steps. For now, please just add one social activity that you find difficult at the moment. You don't have to think about steps yet. Let's try! After the activity, you can either go directly to part 2 of module 4 or do that another time, as you like.
 Social Activities	Social activity exercise People are asked to list social activities they want to try. Social activities help us to build social support and feel better. For an example see section 2.8 Social activity exercise.

Part 2***Social support***

Celine and Maya tell you how their friends supported them, and Dr Luna explains where you can access additional support, if needed.

Celine asks for support

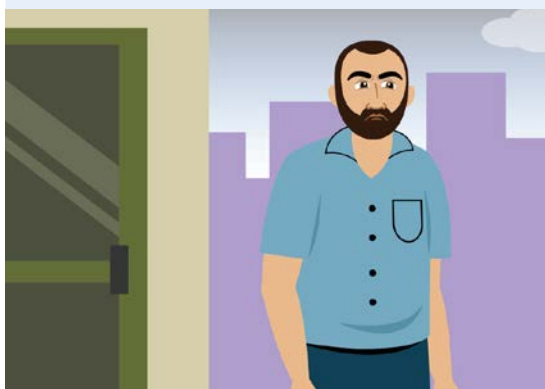
Let's start this part with Celine.

A few days later, Mona invited me to visit a friend of ours who had just had a baby.

But when that evening came, I had forgotten that Michel had arranged to play cards with his friends.

The children would be alone ...

“Just take them with you, Celine,” he snapped at me. “Stop bothering me with this. You’re their mother.”



Michel left the house, slamming the door. I had let everyone down.

I felt stressed and considered different options.

I should just cancel, I thought.

But I knew how important it was to keep up social activities.

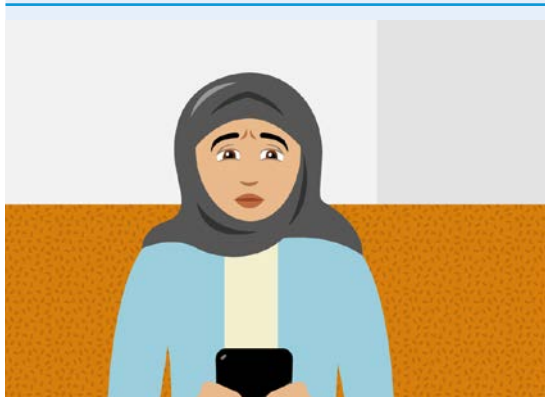


Dr Luna had already warned me about cancelling.

What's more, I wanted to see Mona.

I had started to feel excited about seeing the baby.

I hated myself for forgetting Michel's plans.



I texted Mona that I couldn't make it. She replied quickly:

"Why don't you see if Sara can help? She loves your kids, and doesn't she live in the neighbourhood?"

The last thing I felt like doing was asking anyone for help.

People had their own lives and problems.

But on the other hand, I thought: will it hurt to ask?



I dialled through to Sara.

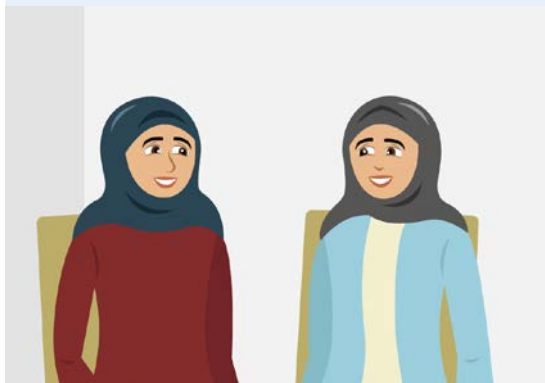
To my surprise she was free and happy to look after my children.

“I don’t know how to thank you...” I said when she arrived.

“Are you kidding?” laughed Sara. “I love these guys! And honestly, it’s a relief to get away from my mother.”

Nadia had already jumped on Sara, giggling away.

I realized my children had missed my friends too.



I told Mona what had happened, and she smiled.

“That’s what friends are for,” said Mona, as we approached our friend’s house. “Besides, how many times have you helped Sara out? Loads!”

As we knocked on the door, I felt lighter than I had in a long time.

I felt supported by my friends.

Let’s hear from Maya now.

Maya needs a helping hand



Not long after coffee with my classmates, it was time for my cousin's wedding.

I immediately panicked: I had not worn a dress for years.

My first thought was to stay home, but my mother would not hear of it.

"You will go to this wedding!" she yelled at me.

"This is Leila's special day! What else are you doing? And how else will you meet a husband?"

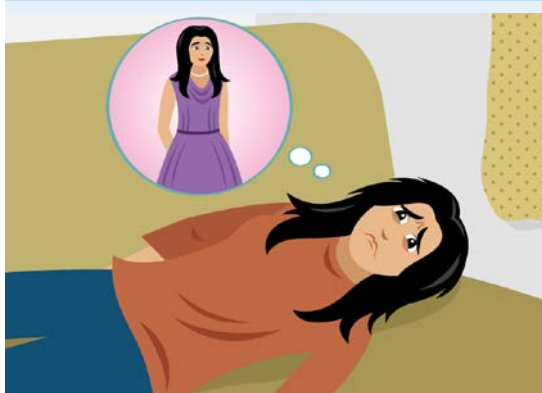


"Mama, I have my studies!" I yelled back. "I can't just abandon everything."

My mother started crying.

"I just want my daughter to be happy," she told me.

"Mama, don't cry," I said. "If it's so important to you, and Leila, I'll come."



I felt stressed and asked myself why I didn't want to go.

Maybe because I knew nothing about wedding dresses and make-up ...

I had spent so long avoiding looking at myself in the mirror, I barely knew what I looked like. I should just cancel, I thought.

But I didn't want to make my mother sad again.



I knew I needed help but I thought : How could I bother someone asking them to help me?

But, on the other hand, I knew someone who could help me.

Julia was beautiful and always dressed well.
I messaged her about the wedding, and she replied immediately:

“OMG! Yes!! When are you free?”



“I don’t know how to thank you,” I said when she arrived that evening, her arms full of make-up kits and fashion magazines.

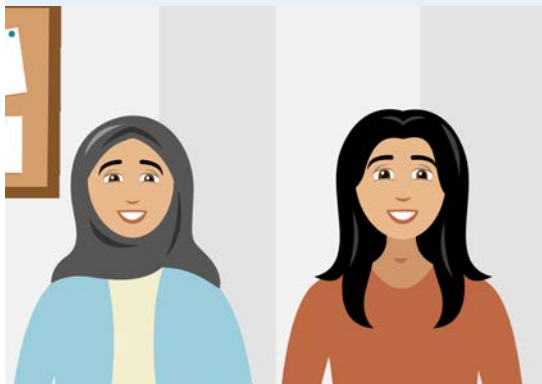
“Are you kidding?” laughed Julia. “I love weddings! And honestly, it’s a relief to have a night off from studying.”

“I know what you mean,” I smiled back.

“This is what friends are for, Maya,” said Julia, pulling me into a hug.

Let’s hear from Celine and Maya, they have another message for you.

Celine and maya have a message for you



Asking for help is an important step towards taking better care of yourself.

You can’t do everything all the time.

If, like us, you don’t want to bother others with your problems, ask yourself:

If you knew someone you care about was struggling, wouldn’t you want to help them?

They probably feel the same way about you.

Supporting each other is so important.

Let’s return to Dr Luna, who has another essential piece of advice to share with you.



This exchange of support can help you feel part of a friendship, relationship or community.

You can use the social activities exercise from part 1 to schedule asking for help with something you find hard.

You could also schedule in doing something nice for someone else.

You might like to break your ideas into steps or add any potential obstacles to your plans.

Let's get back to Celine.



I was lucky to have friends like Sara and Mona.

The next time I saw Dr Luna, I told her what had happened, and she asked me if I found it easy to ask for help.

I shook my head.

I told her how I worry about my children being affected by me feeling this way. My little boy, Sami, didn't seem himself sometimes.

She mentioned that this is common. She reminded me to reach out to friends and that there were organizations that could help me.

Let's hear from Dr Luna, who will explain to you how organizations could help you.



There are helpful organizations ready to support you with a range of problems.

Remember, it is okay to get help if you need it.

Like Celine, you might be struggling with difficulties with your children; or you might need help to get organized.

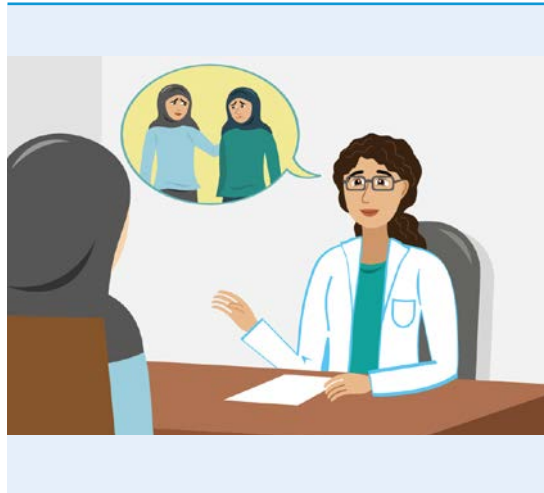
Other people might be struggling financially, or need different kinds of outside support, such as livelihood, support or training.



Your friends can advise you about local organizations.

You can also take a look at the following list of organizations that you could contact.

[Adaptation note: here you can add a list of local organizations]



Helping others and accepting help from others are important steps in feeling better in your daily life.

Overcoming challenges is not always easy, but I hope you're managing well using your new techniques.

You've worked yourself through four modules now.

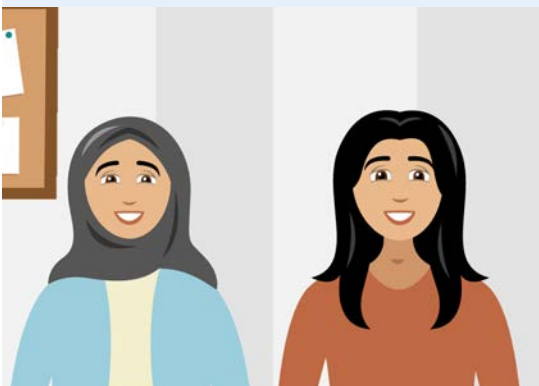
I hope you feel really proud of yourself.

You have now reached the end of this module. You can continue to the last module or come back to it later.

Module 5: Remember, change takes time

Part 1

Learning about warning signs



Celine and Maya tell you about the ups and downs they experienced after they stopped seeing Dr Luna.

Dr Luna shows you how you can cope with feeling low in the future by introducing a new exercise. It is called the “warning signs” exercise.



Welcome back to Step-by-Step!

It's great to see you back here in module 5, the final one.

Let's first hear about Maya's experience.

Maya's experience after Step-by-Step

I was surprised by how much better I felt after Step-by-Step.

I felt better than I had in years ...

Making the techniques part of my life gave me more energy.

I could get through my day, study, support my mother, and sometimes even enjoy it.

I could look at myself in the mirror again and say:

I'm okay.



"You seem brighter," my mum said, stroking my cheek.

She was right.

Leila's wedding was beautiful and I enjoyed being there.

I was seeing my classmates regularly. We were getting closer. I felt like I had friends.

I was doing well at school ...

I didn't want to go back to that dark place again.

Habits became routines as the weeks passed, and after a few months, I felt genuinely better with myself.

But then the exam season came.



I did my best to stay calm, but the pressure got too much.

I felt myself slipping into old patterns...

All I did was study, but it was hard to concentrate when I ate so little.

I didn't do well in my exams. I felt anxious all the time ...

Negative thoughts clouded my days and I felt myself closing off.

Now let's hear from Celine and her experience after the end of the Step-by-Step programme.

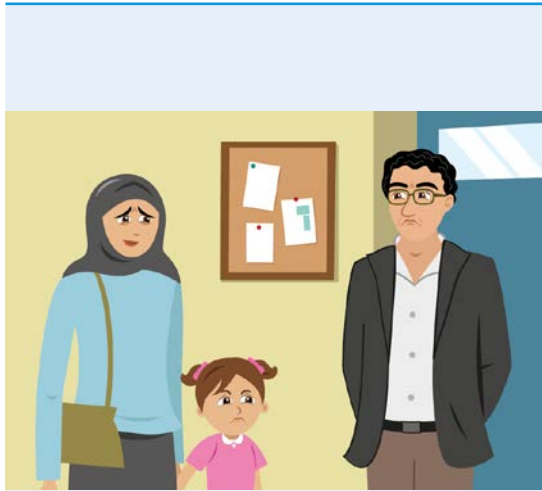
Celine's experience after Step-by-Step



The house was starting to feel like a home again. Friends were coming to visit.

The children were happier too ...

But then my husband lost his job.



He was in the house all day and things changed.

We started fighting again.

The sleepless nights returned.

One day I was asked to collect my daughter, Nadia, from school, for bad behaviour.

“Is everything all right at home?” her teacher asked me.

“Yes, all’s fine,” I lied, forcing a smile.

I felt ashamed.

I was too tired to explain.



Everything was spiralling out of control again.

“Celine, call Dr Luna,” Mona urged me.

We had stopped our modules several weeks ago, as I had been feeling much better.

“Don’t forget how far you’ve come,” she said. “This is life happening ... you just need to get back on track, Celine.”



I had come a long way, yes.

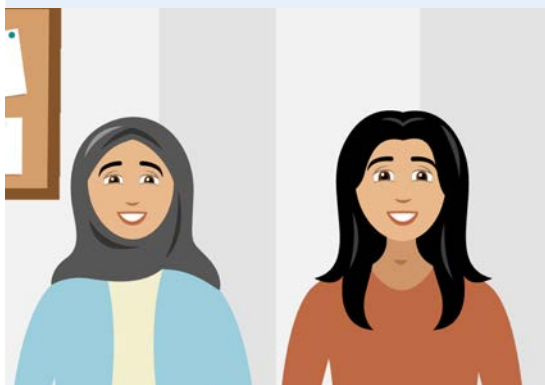
But life has ups and downs.

How could I fall back into such bad patterns of thinking and behaviour?

I blamed myself.

Let's hear now from Celine and Maya, who have a piece of advice to share with you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



If you still find yourself thinking “I’m not good at anything,” know that it happened to us as well.

This negativity frightened us so much.

It's normal to have ups and downs. Change does not happen immediately! Keep trying!

Let's return to Dr Luna, who will show you how you can cope with feeling low in the future.

Detect the warning signs



Like Celine and Maya, you have shown a lot of strength in completing this programme.

I hope you are starting to feel confident with the techniques you learnt and have noticed some changes in your life.

If you haven't, or you're still not feeling any better, keep going. Remember: change does not happen immediately.

You are doing something for yourself right now by coming to module 5.



Today's main message is:

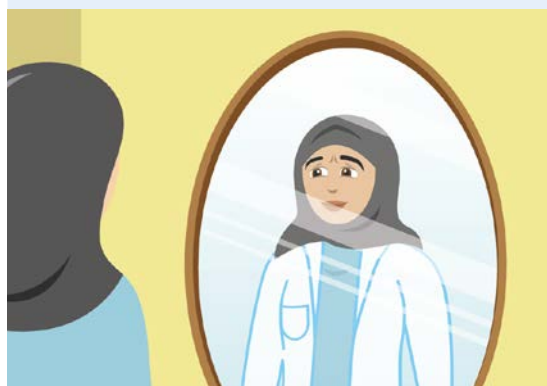
It is normal to have ups and downs, especially when we think we are doing okay again.

We cannot control what changes life brings, only how we cope with those changes.

It can help to recognize early signs within yourself that you don't feel good again.

Sometimes you might feel stressed, sad or anxious.

The best thing you can do is be prepared.



Recognizing that you are struggling and knowing what to do will help you to feel better before it gets worse.

Observe yourself and be aware of what is not feeling good.

This way you can work on any emotional distress before it gets too much for you to cope with.



In the upcoming exercise, you will think about the signs that show you are not coping so well anymore.

These are your warning signs.

It could be that you feel sad or tense more often (like Maya), do not sleep well, have negative thoughts (like Celine), or start withdrawing from your friends.

How do you know when you are starting to feel worse?

Let's take a moment now to add some warning signs to your toolbox.

This list works exactly the same as the previous lists in your toolbox.

Let's try!

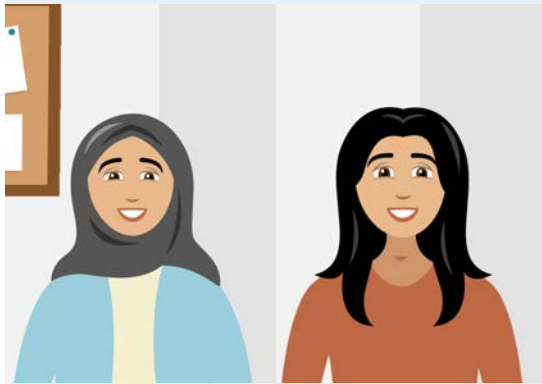
As always, after the activity, you can go directly to the second part of module 5 or come back any time during the following days.



Your Warning Signs

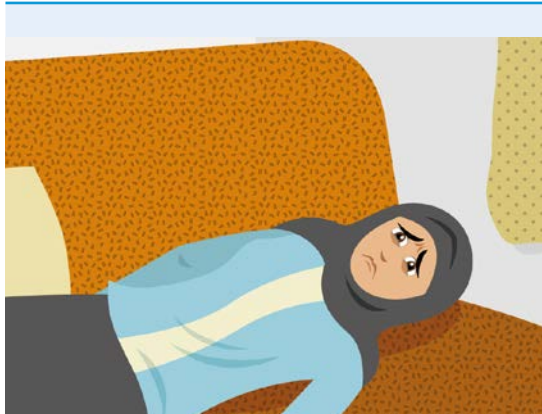
Warning signs exercise

People are asked to list their warning signs. Knowing our warning signs, and how to cope with them, helps us to feel good again. For an example see section [2.9 Warning signs exercise](#).

Part 2***Responding to warning signs***

Celine and Maya tell you how they responded to their warning signs and how helpful it was to be prepared.

Dr Luna explains how to get prepared using the warning signs exercise.

Celine's response to warning signs

Let's hear from Celine and her experience dealing with her warning signs.

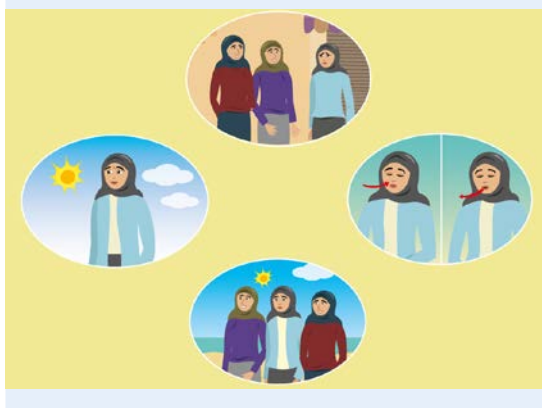
I hadn't had the time or energy to notice what was happening when things went wrong.

It was all so overwhelming ...

But I knew I had pain in my neck again, and I couldn't stop arguing with Michel.

It was hard to help the children with their homework because I was so exhausted.

Seeing friends, even Mona, felt too much.



But after seeing Dr Luna, I remembered there were techniques I could call to mind.

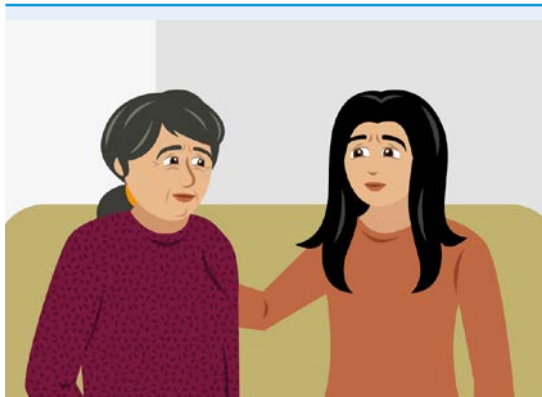
I started to practise the breathing exercise again, to release the tension in my neck.

The grounding exercise helped me to get going every morning.

When I felt a bit better, I reached out to Sara, and a local organization, to help me.

Let's see now how Maya coped with her warning signs.

Maya's response to the warning signs



When I started criticizing myself for not doing things, I remembered to talk to myself as if I was talking to a friend.

This kindness also extended to my mother.

We got along better.

Slowly, I felt okay again, despite having to resit the exams.

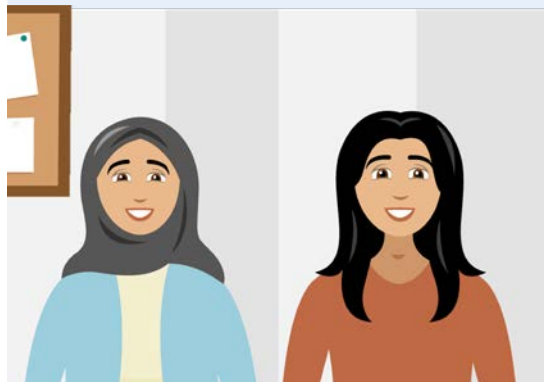


I followed Dr Luna's advice and wrote down a few things I could do when my Warning Signs came.

Be kind to myself
Plan in some time to wash my hair
Slow breathing
Call Julia
Do something that makes me feel good again
Spend time with other people

Speaking from experience, Celine and Maya have a message for you.

Celine and Maya have a message for you



We still feel down sometimes.

And we can't control what life throws at us ...

But we feel good about the techniques we learnt.

We are far from that dark place we were in before we started the programme.

And we can say from our experience that the only person who can put what you have learnt into practice is you.

So, do your best.
And know that your best is always good enough.

Let's return to Dr Luna, who will show you how to cope with warning signs.

Learn to cope with warning signs

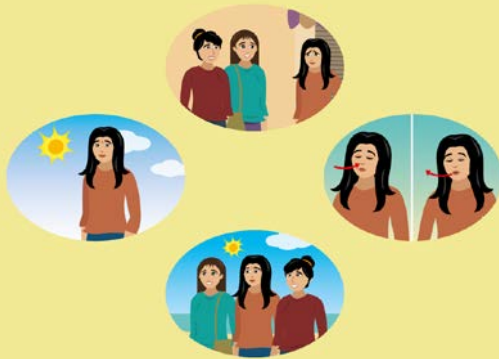


It is normal to feel worse again every once in a while.

It's important to remember the techniques you have learnt in Step-by-Step. They can help you get through difficult times.

Breaking the sadness and withdrawal cycle is a bit like keeping fit ...

You need to practise in order to keep up your strength and fitness.



Let's think about what we've practised in this programme.

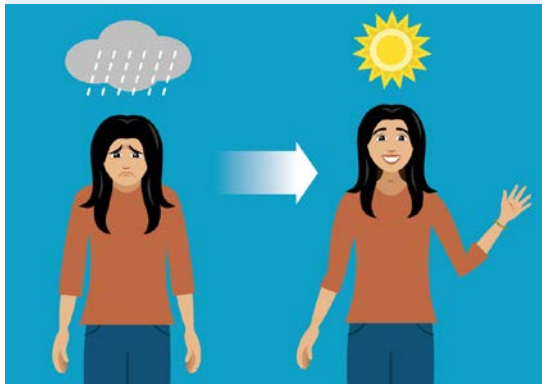
We've practised reducing stress with the breathing and the grounding exercises.

We've practised breaking the sadness and withdrawal cycle in this programme by:

Doing small things we enjoy.

Carefully planning bigger things we enjoy, and breaking them into smaller steps.

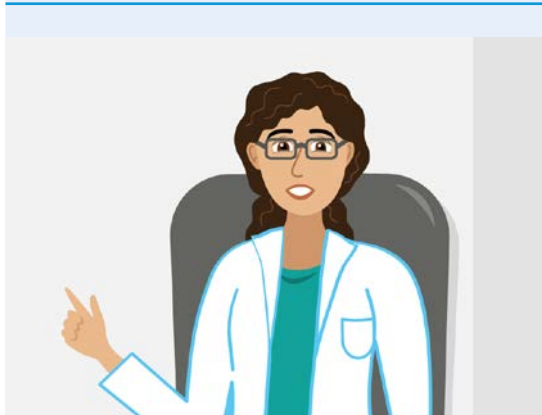
Recognizing challenges to our plans, and finding solutions.



And we have practised being kind to ourselves if we do not manage to do things as we would like to.

It is important to notice signs that you are not doing well.

It's time to think of the ways you can cope with your warning signs when they come up.



You will now see the list of warning signs you made in part 1.

You can add ideas for how you would like to cope with these signs by clicking on each warning sign.

As with the other techniques, you can always access it in your toolbox to change or edit it.

Let's try!

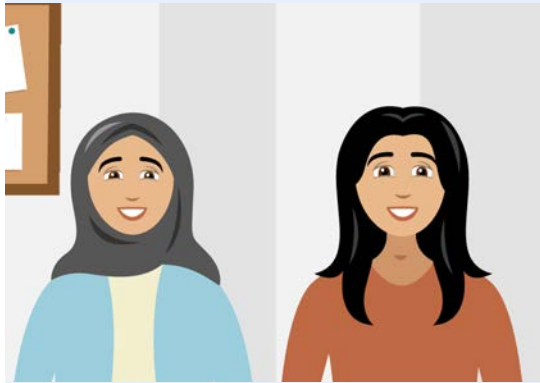
After the activity, you can now go directly to the last part of module 5, or come back later, as you wish.



Your Warning Signs

Warning signs exercise

People are asked to list coping for their warning signs. Knowing our warning signs, and how to cope with them, helps us to feel good again. For an example see section [2.9 Warning signs exercise](#).

Part 3***Celine and Maya say goodbye***

Looks like it's time for us to say goodbye.

We hope you're feeling better than when we first met ...

It's great that you've come this far, well done!

Thanks for listening to our stories.

Don't forget to reach out for the support that's around you.

You're not alone.

Dr Luna congratulates you

Congratulations on reaching the end of Step-by-Step!

Please take a moment to realize what you have achieved over the past few weeks.

You have invested in improving your situation with courage and determination.

We hope you feel really proud of yourself.

Try to keep these techniques a part of your daily life, and notice when you're feeling better.

You did it!



You have finished the programme!

Remember, you can access your techniques and lists at any time by simply going to your toolbox.

It's great to see you at this final goodbye.

We hope that as you step forward in your life, this programme has been helpful in some way.

We wish you the very best for your future!

Section 2: SbS exercises

2.1 Grounding exercise (exercise 1)

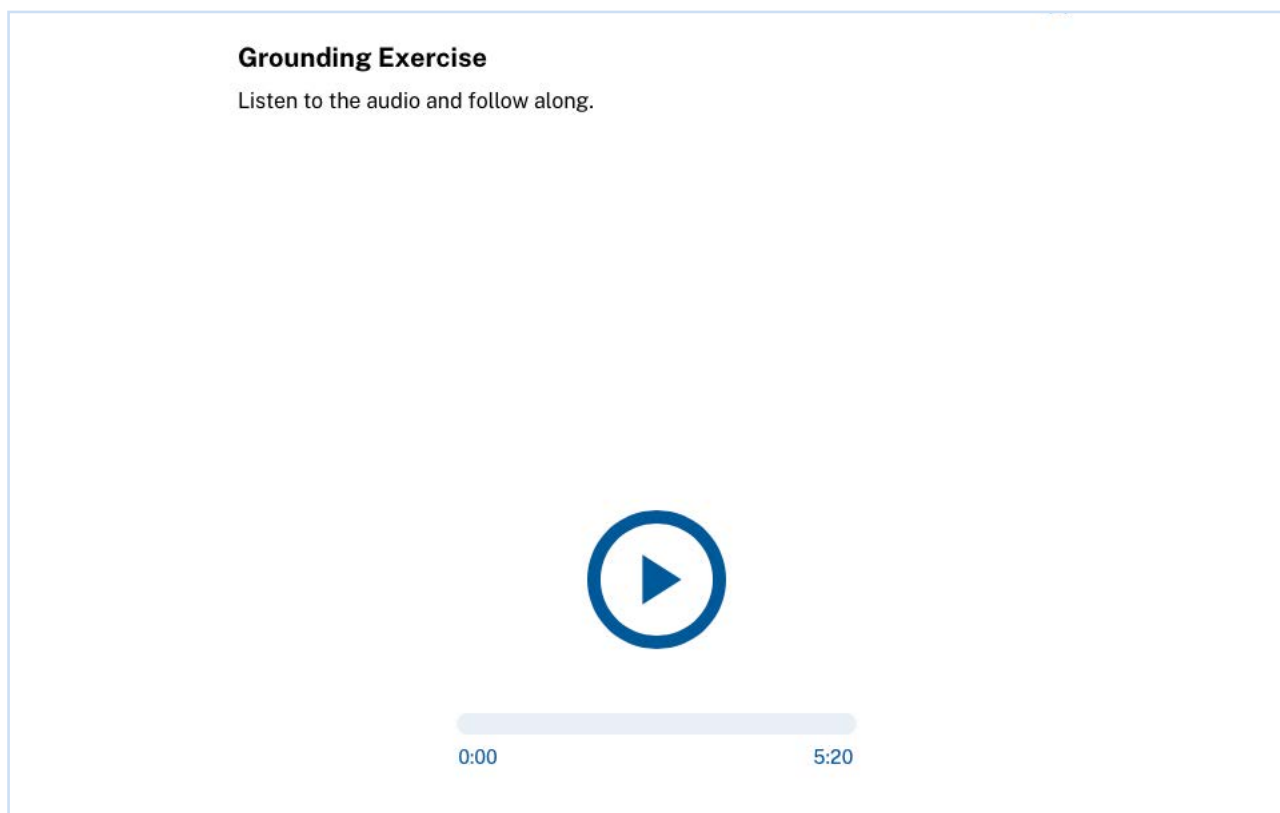
- Below you will find a script for the grounding exercise.
- This exercise works best if people can listen to it. In the SbS randomized controlled trials (RCTs), the grounding exercise was included as an audio on the platform.
- An example audio that has been used in Lebanon can be found here: <https://who.canto.global/b/H0IMU>. The script might differ a bit from the shared audio. Both are examples of a grounding exercise and can be adapted to your context.
- Depending on how you are implementing SbS, you can use the existing audio, record a new audio, or present the grounding exercise in a different way, for example as a video or in written format.

Script for grounding exercise

- *To help you to relax, let's try a brief exercise. Every now and again there will be a five-second pause in the recording, which is part of the exercise, so just keep following the exercise whenever there is a pause.*
- *Sometimes we feel like we're caught up in a storm of thoughts and emotions. The grounding exercise is a quick and easy way to feel more present in the moment without worrying about the past or future.*
- *You can practise this exercise no matter how you are feeling right now. Even if you feel fine at this moment, you can still practise this exercise. Just follow all the steps.*
- *Make sure to sit in a silent place where you are not distracted or disturbed.*
- *We invite you to sit straight. You might wish to close your eyes to help you avoid distractions and become fully engaged in this exercise. If you do not want to close your eyes, then fix your gaze on a spot. Take a moment to notice what you are thinking and how you are feeling, right now.*
(Pause 5 seconds)
- *Next, find a way to slow down. Slow your breathing. Breathe in and out through your nose. Empty your lungs completely, and then let them refill as slowly as possible.*
(Pause 5 seconds)
- *If you feel dizzy or light-headed, it's okay, it means you are breathing too fast or too deeply – so breathe slowly and gently, and focus on exhaling.*
(Pause 5 seconds)
- *Slowly press your feet into the floor.*
(Pause 5 seconds)

- *Slowly stretch your arms, or if you prefer, press your hands firmly together.
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *Get a sense of yourself slowing down.
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *Now notice where you are. Look around you, with curiosity.
What are five things you can see?
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *What are three or four things you can hear?
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *Breathe in the air: what is it like – warm, cool, fresh, stale, dry, or humid? What can you smell in the air?
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *What movements and sensations can you notice in your shoulders?
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *What movements and sensations can you notice in your chest?
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *What movements and sensations can you notice in your belly?
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *Notice where you are and what you are doing.
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *Reach out and touch something, and notice what it feels like under your fingers.
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *Stretch your body in some way. Stretch your arms or legs or back or neck.
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *Try to notice when your attention has wandered. This is normal – as it happens, acknowledge it, and then gently bring your attention back to the present moment.*
- *Notice that while there might be difficult thoughts or feelings appearing, there is also a world around you that you can see and hear and smell and touch.*
- *Now take a moment to notice how you feel.
(Pause 5 seconds)*
- *Hopefully you feel a bit less caught up in your thoughts and feelings, and are noticing and feel more connected with the world around you.*
- *If this did not happen for you, or if you feel a bit strange, then remember such reactions are common. Usually, with practice, this exercise will start to feel more natural, and the results will be more powerful.*

(Screenshot of the exercise in the digital platform used for SbS in Lebanon)



2.2 Breathing exercise (exercise 2)

- Below you will find a script for the breathing exercise.
- This exercise works best if people can listen to it. In the SbS RCTs, the breathing exercise was included as an audio on the platform.
- An example audio that has been used in Lebanon can be found here: <https://who.canto.global/b/H0IMU>. The script might differ a bit from the shared audio. Both are examples of a breathing exercise and can be adapted to your context.
- Depending on how you are implementing SbS, you can use the existing audio, record a new audio, or present the breathing exercise in a different way, for example as a video or in written format.

Slow breathing script

- *This recording will guide you through a slow breathing exercise. I will give you instructions to follow and at times I will stop talking so you have time to practise.*
(Pause 1 second)
- *When we feel stressed, we tend to take shorter, quick little breaths. This can make us feel even more tense. Slowing down your breathing can help to reduce stress and tension.*
(Pause 1 second)
- *Before we start, I want you to relax your body a bit.*
- *Shake out your arms and legs and let them go floppy and loose. Take a few seconds to do that now.*
(Pause 5 seconds)
- *Great, now try to sit in a comfortable position with your back straight. Roll your shoulders back and gently move your head from side to side.*
(Pause 5 seconds)
- *Okay, we're ready to begin.*
(Pause 1 second)
- *We are going to start by breathing in through the nose and out through the mouth.*
(Pause 1 second)
- *Take a few breaths now, in through your nose and out through your mouth. You don't have to make an effort, just breathe normally and focus on exhaling.*
(Pause 10 seconds)
- *That's great, now just take a few more.*
(Pause 5 seconds)
- *Okay, good. Now the second step is to slow your breathing down. Try to take around three seconds to breathe in through your nose and three seconds to breathe out through your mouth. I will count for you.*
- *So breathe in, one (1 second), two (1 second), three (1 second). And breathe out, one (1 second), two (1 second), three (1 second). And again, breathe in, one (1 second), two (1 second), three (1 second). And*

breathe out, one (1 second), two (1 second), three (1 second).

(Pause 1 second)

- *Do you notice how slowly I counted? That is about how long it can take for you to take a slow breath in and out.*
- *We will now repeat this exercise for about half a minute and I will count the breaths for us.*
(Count breaths for about 30 seconds)
- *How was that for you?*
(Pause 2 seconds)
- *Take a few moments to just notice how your body feels. Has there been any change?*
Do you feel less tense?
(Pause 5 seconds)
- *If not, that is okay. I would encourage you to practise because over time, this technique could help.*
(Pause 1 second)
- *When practising slow breathing, it can help to try to count the seconds to yourself as I have done, or you can try concentrating on the sensation of the air coming in through your nose, down into your lungs and back out through your mouth.*
- *Either way, if other stressful thoughts enter your mind while doing the breathing exercise, just try and bring your concentration back to your breathing.*
- *When you practise on your own, don't be concerned about trying to keep exactly to three seconds. Just try your best to slow your breathing down, and do what feels right.*
- *Remember that the aim is to help reduce your stress, so if you find yourself becoming more stressed from doing this, or worrying about doing it right, then just do whatever feels good and does not cause you stress.*
- *Okay, so now try on your own for the next few minutes. I will count you in at first and then leave you to try it on your own for a couple more minutes. Some people prefer to close their eyes, it is up to you; you can close them if you wish.*
- ***Continue counting the breathing exercise for eight in and out breaths (28 seconds)***

(Screenshot of the exercise in the digital platform used for SbS in Lebanon)



2.3 Gratitude list (exercise 3)

- The gratitude list exercise consists of instructions, a place where people can list things and examples.
- In the SbS RCTs, empty lists that could be filled out were included in the platform. The lists also showed some examples.
- People can also be asked to write down a list with pen and paper, or an empty list format can be printed for people to fill out. It is also possible to give the opportunity for people to add photos or voice recordings to their list.
- Below you can find the instructions for the exercise.

Instructions for exercise

It may seem hard to believe, but remembering things we are grateful for, no matter how small, can help reduce stress, especially when practised over time.

To use this technique, take a few minutes to think of three things you are grateful for. These can be anything, big or small.

For example, think of a person who was kind to you, something you did for yourself, something you did for others, something you learnt, or someone you are grateful to have in your life. It can be any small everyday thing or anything you particularly appreciate in your current life.

In the gratitude list you can either write, record or take a photo of things you feel grateful for.

You can then look at this list whenever you need to and be reminded of the things you are grateful for in your life.

Let's give it a try ...

(Screenshot of the exercise in the digital platform used for SbS in Lebanon)

Gratitude list

Make a list of things (small or big) that you are grateful for.

☐ my best friends 

☐ morning coffee 

☐ believing in myself 

[+ Add new](#)

 Our suggestions:

My family [Add](#)

Nature [Add](#)

Cup of warm coffee or tea [Add](#)

My neighbour cooking for me [Add](#)

Save and exit

2.4 Small activities exercise (exercise 4)

- The small activities exercise consists of instructions, a place where people can list things and examples.
- In the SbS RCTs, empty lists that could be filled out were included in the platform.
- People can also be asked to write down a list with pen and paper or an empty list format can be printed for people to fill out. It is also possible to give the opportunity for people to add photos or voice recordings to their list.
- Below you can find the instructions for the exercise. The list can be presented to people in different ways. In a digital version of SbS, it can be presented like this:

Instructions for small activities exercise

In this next technique, called “small activities”, I will ask you to write down three small things you would normally enjoy doing.

You might feel like including the stress reduction exercises we’ve tried together so far, or Celine’s idea of a walk outside.

Try to think of something that made you feel good in the past.

If you’re having trouble thinking of small activities, here are some examples:

- *Taking time to enjoy moments with family or friends*
- *Going for a walk*
- *Listening to your favourite singer*
- *Watching a funny film*
- *Trying the breathing or grounding technique*
- *Doing something nice for someone else.*

You can add to your list of small activities at any time.

Let’s give it a try now.

(Screenshot of the exercise in the digital platform used for SbS in Lebanon)

Small Activities -

Create a checklist of enjoyable activities.

☐ hanging out with my friends 

☐ going for a walk on the beach 

☐ Listening to my favourite singer 

[+ Add new](#)

 Our suggestions:

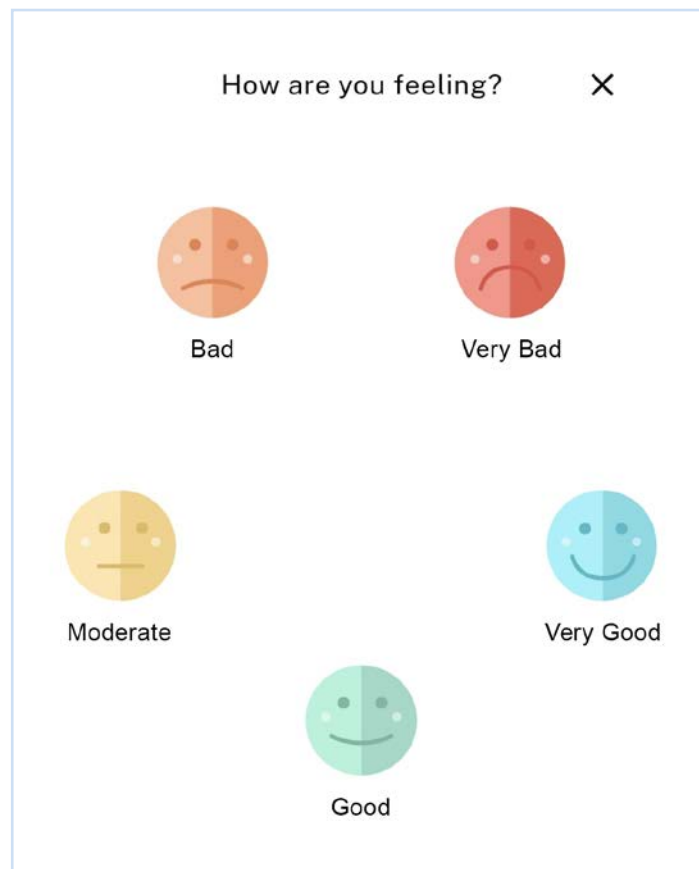
Going for a walk	Add
Listening to your favourite singer	Add
Praying/meditation, reading	Add
Taking time to enjoy moments with family or friends	Add

[Save and exit](#)

2.5 Mood Tracker (exercise 5)

- The Mood Tracker exercise consist of instructions and a place where people can indicate their mood and write notes.
- In the SbS RCTs, empty lists that could be filled out were included in the platform.
- People can also be asked to write down a list with pen and paper, or an empty list format can be printed for people to fill out. It is also possible to give the opportunity for people to add photos or voice recordings to their list.
- Below you can find the instructions for the exercise. The list can be presented to people in different ways. In a digital version of SbS, it can be presented like this:

(Screenshot of the exercise in the digital platform used for SbS in Lebanon)



2.6 Breaking activities down exercise (exercise 6)

- The breaking activities down exercise consists of instructions and a place where people can list things and break them down into smaller parts.
- In the SbS RCTs, empty lists that could be filled out were included in the platform.
- People can also be asked to write down a list with pen and paper, or an empty list format can be printed for people to fill out. It is also possible to give the opportunity for people to add photos or voice recordings to their list.
- Below you can find the instructions for the exercise. The list can be presented to people in different ways. In a digital version of SbS, it can be presented like this:

Instructions for breaking activities down exercise

If you feel you would like to try something a bit more challenging, you can break your activity down into smaller and easier steps too!

In the next exercise, I am going to ask you to make a list of more challenging activities.

Please think about an activity you would really like to do.

This should be something you used to enjoy doing but now seems overwhelming.

It can help to choose something clear and specific, and something you can plan for.

Try something challenging, but start small – don't go for the most challenging activity too soon. Just as Celine and Maya did, let's break the activity down into all the essential steps.

Let me give you an example to help you:

I would like to tidy the house.

If I break this activity down into manageable steps, here are the steps I'd have to think about:

1. *Getting out of bed*
2. *Getting dressed appropriately for tidying*
3. *Planning which cleaning materials I might need*
4. *Clean the bathroom and kitchen*
5. *Make beds*
6. *Sweep the floor.*

Your own chosen activity might be easier if broken down into smaller steps.

(Screenshot of the exercise in the digital platform used for SbS in Lebanon)

Challenging Activities

Tidy and clean the house

...

Challenging activities help you learn how to break a difficult task into small, manageable steps so you can complete it more easily.

- ☐ Get out of bed
- ☐ Get dressed so I can clean and tidy
- ☐ Think about what materials I need to clean
- ☐ Collect or buy materials
- ☐ Clean the bathroom
- ☐ Clean the kitchen
- ☐ Make the beds
- ☐ Sweep the floors

+ Add step for activity

+ Add new activity

 Save and exit

2.7 Kind to yourself exercise (exercise 7)

- The kind to yourself exercise consists of instructions and a place where people can list things.
- In the SbS RCTs, empty lists that could be filled out were included in the platform.
- People can also be asked to write down a list with pen and paper, or an empty list format can be printed for people to fill out. It is also possible to give the opportunity for people to add photos or voice recordings to their list.
- Below you can find the instructions for the exercise. The list can be presented to people in different ways. In a digital version of SbS, it can be presented like this:

Instructions for kind to yourself exercise

Try to imagine the things you might say to a friend facing a difficult situation, so you could say the same to yourself.

Some examples are:

“It’s okay to feel like this, many people do.”

“These activities are hard, but they will get easier.”

“I am really helping myself by taking these steps.”

“I am trying my best, and that’s okay.”

What would you say to yourself to show kindness and support?

Let’s go to a new technique called “kind to yourself” in your toolbox.

I would like you to create at least one entry with kind words to yourself. If you can’t think of anything, copy one of the examples above.

This list works exactly like the lists before.

Remember, these words of kindness are available to you whenever you want to read them.

You can always find them in your toolbox.

Stay positive, you are doing well.

As always, you can now go directly to the third part of module 3, or come back to it later, as you wish.

(Screenshot of the exercise in the digital platform used for SbS in Lebanon)

Kind to yourself

Add kind words to yourself to this list.

☐ It doesn't have to be perfect 

☐ Don't be too hard on yourself 

☐ Your family and friends love you 

[+ Add new](#)

 Our suggestions:

It's okay to feel like this, many people do. [Add](#)

I am really helping myself by taking these steps. [Add](#)

These activities are hard, but they will get easier. [Add](#)

[Save and exit](#)

2.8 Social activity exercise (exercise 8)

- The social activity exercise consist of instructions and a place where people can list things.
- In the SbS RCTs, empty lists that could be filled out were included in the platform.
- People can also be asked to write down a list with pen and paper, or an empty list format can be printed for people to fill out. It is also possible to give the opportunity for people to add photos or voice recordings to their list.

Instructions for social activities exercise

In the next exercise I would like you to make a list of social activities that you would like to start doing again.

Why not think of something you used to enjoy doing with someone, which now seems quite overwhelming?

Or something you would like to do more of?

Some people would choose to invite their friends over for dinner ...

Other people enjoy family gatherings or meeting friends or neighbours for coffee.

This may feel difficult for you.

If you feel this way, don't worry.

Planning and trying them can make socializing a possibility for you again.

Let's think of one social activity you can try now.

This list works exactly the same as the previous lists, such as "small activities" and "breaking activities down".

You can create entries and break them into steps.

For now, please just add one social activity that you find difficult at the moment.

You don't have to think about steps yet.

Let's try!

(Screenshot of the exercise in the digital platform used for SbS in Lebanon)

Social Activities

Create a checklist of enjoyable activities that involve other people.

☐ Texting or talking to a friend 

☐ Cook or have dinner with a friend 

☐ Play a game with a friend 

[+ Add new](#)

 Our suggestions:

Go for a walk with a friend [Add](#)

[Save and exit](#)

2.9 Warning signs exercise (exercise 9)

- The warning signs exercise consists of two parts of instructions and a place where people can list things.
- In the SbS RCTs, empty lists that could be filled out were included in the platform.
- People can also be asked to write down a list with pen and paper, or an empty list format can be printed for people to fill out. It is also possible to give the opportunity for people to add photos or voice recordings to their list.

Instructions for warning signs exercise

Part A: Warning signs

In the upcoming exercise, you will think about the signs that show you are not coping so well any more.

These are your warning signs.

It could be that you feel sad or tense more often, like Maya, do not sleep well, have negative thoughts like Celine, or start withdrawing from your friends.

How do you know when you are starting to feel worse?

Let's take a moment now to add some warning signs to your toolbox.

This list works exactly the same as the previous lists in your toolbox.

Let's try!

Our suggestions:

- *Having negative thoughts*
- *Feeling exhausted*
- *Feeling tense*
- *Withdrawing from my friends.*

Part B: Coping

Let's think about what we've practised in this programme.

We've practised reducing stress with the breathing and the grounding exercises.

We've practised breaking the "sadness and withdrawal cycle" in this programme by doing small things we enjoy ...

Carefully planning bigger things we enjoy, and breaking them into smaller steps ...

And recognizing challenges to our plans, and finding solutions.

We have also practised being kind to ourselves if we do not manage to do things as we would like to.

It is important to notice signs that you are not doing well.

It's time to think of the ways you can cope with your warning signs when they come up.

You will now see the list of warning signs you made in part A.

You can add ideas on how you would like to cope with these signs by clicking on each warning sign.

As with the other techniques, you can always access it in your toolbox to change or edit it.

Let's try!

(Screenshot of the exercise in the digital platform used for SbS in Lebanon)

Warning Signs

headaches

Warning signs are early signals from our body and mind, like anger, poor sleep, or frequent crying, that show we may be feeling unwell again. Noticing and preparing for these signs can help us protect ourselves from relapse.

☐ relaxation exercises

+ Add solution for warning sign

Sleeping poorly

Warning signs are early signals from our body and mind, like anger, poor sleep, or frequent crying, that show we may be feeling unwell again. Noticing and preparing for these signs can help us protect ourselves from relapse.

☐ Have coffee with a friend

+ Add solution for warning sign

+ Add new warning sign

Save and exit

Section 3: Adaptation and implementation guidance.

Adaptation of SbS

This section provides information on adapting SbS.

To adapt SbS, start by reading the following information:

- Chapter 3 of WHO’s Psychological interventions implementation manual, which sets out the goals of and strategies for adaptation of diverse psychological interventions;
- section 2.2 of WHO’s manual ‘[Psychological self-help interventions; delivering self-help for individuals, featuring step-by-step and doing what matters in times of stress guided self-help manual](#)’

In addition, you will need the full adaptation and translation pack that contains all content needed for running SbS. See the introduction to this document for more information.

The package is based on the adaptation of the generic version that was used in Lebanon. This means that all images and examples are tailored for use in Lebanon and require adaptation. The package includes:

- full content of both the male and female storylines for SbS with other information, such as text codes, that supports adaptation to an online system (see screenshot below of this document);
- folders with images;
- scripts for the audio exercises.

Module 1: Start small and reduce stress							
FEMALE STORY				MALE STORY			
Text code	Text female	Image code	Image	Text code	Text male	Image code	Image
1.0	Module 1: Start small and reduce stress			1.0	Module 1: Start small and reduce stress		
	PART 1 (1.1)				PART 1 (1.1)		
1.1.1.h	Introduction Module 1			1.1.1.h	Introduction Module 1		
1.1.1.a	Celine and Maya tell you their story. Dr Luna teaches you a new technique to help you feel calmer and less stressed.			1.1.1.a	Dany and Rayan tell you their story. Dr Rami teaches you a new technique to help you feel calmer and less stressed.		
1.1.1.b	It's great to see you back here, ready for this next step. We hope you had a chance to try the Grounding Exercise. If not, you can always find this technique in the Toolbox via the menu. It's time for you to get to know Celine and Maya. They have also been through difficult times and will share their story with you in this first part of Module 1. You will also have the chance to try a new technique Dr Luna teaches you, called the Breathing Exercise. First, let's say hello to Celine and hear her story.	S1f01		1.1.1.b	It's great to see you back here, ready for this next step. We hope you had a chance to try the Grounding Exercise. If not, you can always find this technique in the Toolbox via the menu. It's time for you to get to know Dany and Rayan. They have also been through difficult times and will share their story with you in this first part of Module 1. You will also have the chance to try a new technique Dr Rami teaches you, called the Breathing Exercise. First, let's say hello to Dany and hear his story.	S1m01	
1.1.2.h	Celine shares her story			1.1.2.h	Dany shares his story		

What is needed to make an online version of SbS?

SbS can run on many online platforms. It was originally designed for use with a bespoke mobile app and website, but improvements in technology mean that e-learning platforms and other similar platforms could potentially be used. To run an online version of SbS you will need software that has the following functionalities:

1. A way of reading or delivering the illustrated and text content, for example, a page where the user can scroll through the content. Content can also be adapted into videos, or with audio screen reading of the text to increase accessibility.
2. The ability for users to access:
 - audio files, such as relaxation exercises;
 - tables into which the user can add activities they plan to do, ideally with some suggested examples;
 - Mood Tracker – a functionality whereby someone can track their moods. There are many apps now available for iOS and Android with this function, which can be found by searching online. If it can't be built into the system, an additional app can be suggested.
3. Ideally, a toolbox section. This is where the user will access any activities that are included in the intervention, for example, listening to a relaxation exercise or completing an activities table or plan. If this is not possible, then exercises can be provided in other ways.
4. Back-end data collection: the platform can record all user answers and key metrics, such as completion of modules or exercises, time spent using the intervention, or other information, depending on monitoring and evaluation needs in the local context.

5. Locking and unlocking of modules: the version of SbS tested in research trials unlocked new content every few days. It is however unclear whether this is beneficial. The advantage is that it stops users from reading all the content in one go, which may help encourage practice of the specific techniques. This may however also be a disadvantage, as it may block users from using the intervention when they have time. The use of this feature can be explored in the adaptation phase
6. An area to add disclaimers, information about the intervention, or other relevant information

In addition to the software for delivering SbS, implementers will also probably need a system for allocating helpers to users and caseload management, as well as recording session notes.

Examples of an online version of SbS

The following screenshots are taken from a version of SbS provided in Lebanon as a national service. They show all major features of the platform.

Landing / home page

Welcome to Step-by-Step!

Below you will see all **5** sessions to guide you through Step-by-Step

✓ **Session 0: Take the first steps!**



Learn how Step-by-Step works. Meet Dr. Mona, your guide through the...

[Review →](#)

✓ **Session 1: Connect with others**



Meet Leila who has been there. Learn new techniques to help you feel better.

[Review →](#)

✓ **Session 2: Get active again**



Learn how to increase activity and do more of what

Delivery of story content

✓ Page 1 of 2

< Previous

Next >



Please think about one small thing that makes you feel a bit better.



This could be something that you enjoyed in the past and might make you feel a little better now.

Leila meets her friends



Toolbox



Grounding Exercise



Breathing Exercise



Gratitude list



Small Activities -



Challenging Activities



Kind to yourself



Social Activities



Warning Signs

Exercises

Gratitude list

Make a list of things (small or big) that you are grateful for.

☐ my best friends
 

☐ morning coffee
 

☐ believing in myself
 

+ Add new

💡 Our suggestions:

My family [Add](#)

Nature [Add](#)

Cup of warm coffee or tea [Add](#)

My neighbour cooking for me [Add](#)

Save and exit

Exercises	✕ Breathing Exercise Listen to the audio and follow along.  0:00 5:56
Mood Tracker	How are you feeling? ✕  Bad  Very Bad  Moderate  Very Good  Good

Assessments
Pre- and post-assessments of psychological distress and other key outcomes (e.g. functioning) can be added to a platform, or collected in another way.

1 of 11

How are you doing? (Post)

Over the last 2 weeks, how often have you been bothered by:

Little interest or pleasure in doing things?

- ☐ Nearly every day
- ☐ More than half the days
- ☐ Several days
- ☐ Not at all

Next

For more information please contact:

World Health Organization

Mental Health and Substance Use Unit

Department of Noncommunicable Diseases and Mental Health

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CH-1211 Geneva 27
Switzerland

Email:
psych_interventions@who.int

Website:
<https://www.who.int/health-topics/mental-health>